

The Lion's Problem

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From Refusal to Authorship

BRIAN DANZYGER

First edition

The Lion's Problem: From Refusal to Authorship

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This book discusses psychological research for general and scholarly readers. It is not clinical advice.

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But tell me, my brethren, what the child can do, which even the lion could not do? Why hath the preying lion still to become a child?

— Friedrich Nietzsche, *Thus Spake Zarathustra*
(trans. Thomas Common)

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A Message from the Author

This book began as a complaint and turned into a question.

The complaint was the familiar one. We are distracted, the feeds are engineered, the institutions have lost our trust, and everyone seems to be shouting at everyone else. I have heard that complaint at dinner tables, in seminar rooms, in podcasts and in the trade press of the companies that build the feeds. I have made it myself many times. At some point I noticed that everyone agreed with it and that nothing changed. That observation became the question this book tries to answer. *Why does a critique that nearly everyone accepts change almost nothing?*

Answering it took me through more fields than I expected. Clinical ethics had already measured the condition I wanted to describe and given it a name. Phenomenology explained why nobody catches the moment of capture. Experimental psychology showed that our sense of having chosen is assembled after the fact. Nietzsche had drawn the shape of the whole problem as a parable about a lion, and Erich Fromm had stated its mechanism nearly sixty years later without citing him. Each field held part of the answer, and each described its part in a vocabulary the others could not easily read. A good deal of the work was translation, and the Glossary at the back of the book is my attempt to leave the dictionary behind for the next reader.

The book was built rather than planned. I started from a rough outline. I rewrote the outline every time a new section was finished, and I reread the whole draft each time to see whether the argument had shifted under me. It usually had. Chapters that were meant to be

supporting material became central, and one chapter I expected to be the heart of the book ended up as a short section of the Introduction. That flexibility was deliberate. An argument that cannot change shape while it is being written has usually decided its conclusions too early. The final ordering of the chapters is the shape the argument settled into, not the shape it started with.

[AUTHOR: a short personal paragraph belongs here, such as the moment the question first became your own, or the scene where you noticed the agreement and the inertia side by side. Only you can write it, and the book is better with it than without it.]

I ask one thing of you as a reader, and it comes from the argument itself. Chapter 7 proposes that agreeing with a book like this one may be the most efficient available way of doing nothing about it. If that is right, nodding along is worth very little. Run the one-minute conduct test in Chapter 7 instead. Then try one of the small arrangements described in Chapter 9 for a week, and notice what changes without keeping score (Chapter 9 explains why a score would defeat the point). Both cost you nothing, and both count for more than agreeing.

Brian Danzyger
[City], 2026

Preface

This is a book about a mismatch. An ordinary citizen of a wealthy democracy is now asked to hold a defensible view on more civilization-scale threats than any population before, and has the power to act on almost none of them. The book argues that this mismatch, more than any single threat, explains a cluster of things that are usually treated separately. Those things are the exhausted shrug of the well-informed, the pull of conspiracy theories, the reflexive speed of online life, and the strange inertness of a critique that nearly everyone accepts.

The thesis can be stated in a few sentences. Our civic vocabulary is fluent in refusal and nearly mute about construction. The authority that now shapes ordinary life is anonymous, so there is nothing for that refusal to push against. Under those conditions people reach for a refusable object. Some find it in a fabricated villain and some in an agentless noun such as “the algorithm.” Neither meets the need it was reached for. The capacity that would let a person move from refusing to building is the capacity to hold an impulse without discharging it and to stay bad at something long enough to get good. That capacity has become the specific target of the most sophisticated optimization process ever pointed at a human being. The remedy that remains within an individual’s reach does not lie in better beliefs or stronger resolve. It lies in better *arrangements*, and at the scale of a society, arrangements means *norms*.

Who this book is for

The argument draws on clinical ethics, social and cognitive psychology, phenomenology, political theory, the history of philosophy and literary criticism. Each of these fields has studied a piece of the problem, and each has named its piece in terms the others do not use. Nursing ethics calls one form of it *moral distress*, political science calls another *low external efficacy*, and Nietzsche's parable gives its civic form the figure of *the lion*. The book proposes that these are overlapping structures seen from different windows, and where it says so, it says what would show the overlap to be wrong. Its method is to translate between the windows without pretending they are one room.

That makes the book useful in several directions. A psychologist will find philosophical structures that predict findings in their own literature. A philosopher will find empirical anchors for claims usually defended by exegesis alone. Sociologists and anthropologists will find a functional account of conspiracy belief and a theory of how norms get built in a new medium. A general reader needs no background in any of these fields. The argument is framed through the United States, where the evidence is richest. Whether it travels is a question Chapter 2 raises and Appendix D lists. Technical terms are defined where they first matter, and all of them are collected in the Glossary, which notes the discipline each term comes from and the nearest equivalents in neighboring fields.

How the book is built

The book has four parts. **Part One** describes the condition: what the strain of modern citizenship actually is, why the culture's only remedy for it is subtraction, and what Nietzsche saw coming. **Part Two** describes the mechanism: the collapse of the interval between stimulus and response, and the reasons nobody catches that collapse happening in their own experience. **Part Three** describes two counterfeits, one disreputable and one respectable. They differ enormously in accuracy and not at all in structure. **Part Four** turns to construction, meaning the capacity it requires and the arrangements that can build it without demanding it in advance. A Conclusion revisits the four-stage path

from Julian Jaynes to David Foster Wallace that framed the project, and revises its last stage in light of everything the book found.

Nineteen numbered propositions carry the argument. They keep the numbers they had in the earlier modular edition of this argument (Appendix A explains the change), so a proposition can be traced across editions. As a result the numbers do not run in order through the chapters, and a reader who meets Proposition 7 before Proposition 5 has not found an error. Appendix B lists all nineteen in numerical order, with the chapter where each is argued.

The evidence for every empirical claim is graded. The grades are collected in Appendix C, and the tests that would show each proposition wrong are listed in Appendix D. The body of the book states its claims plainly, and the appendices keep the record of how sure it is entitled to be.

Introduction: Authority Without a Voice

The weight that organizes nothing

An ordinary American adult can, in a single day and without looking for any of it, meet credible reporting on nuclear escalation doctrine, a pathogen with pandemic potential, measured climate change, artificial intelligence systems whose own developers discuss existential risk, the fragility of the electrical grid and of the financial system, political violence, a contested transfer of power, rising antibiotic resistance, a falling water table, a fault line and, in a slow news week, an asteroid.

Each of these is real, and each has serious people working on it. Any one of them, presented alone, could organize a life. Presented together, they organize nothing.

This book is an attempt to say precisely what that “nothing” is, why it is so heavy, and what can be built in the space it occupies. Its answer runs through four of the oldest questions in philosophy and psychology. What is authority? What happens when it loses its face? What does a person do with a freedom they lack the strength to use? And how does anyone learn to make something new?

Four voices and a path

The project began with a provisional map, a four-stage arc through four thinkers who never cited one another. Julian Jaynes supplied an origin, Friedrich Nietzsche a crisis, Alan Watts a reorientation and David Foster Wallace a practice. The map was useful because it was

wrong in an instructive place, and the Conclusion returns to it to say where. It also had a gap, which a fifth voice, Erich Fromm, fills below. As a way into the argument it is still the clearest path, so here it is.

The voice. In *The Origin of Consciousness in the Breakdown of the Bicameral Mind*, Jaynes (1976) proposed that the introspective self is a late cultural invention. On his account the people of the early Bronze Age did not deliberate. They heard commands, experienced as the voices of gods, and obeyed them. Jaynes's history is contested, and this book does not rest any claim on it. It earns its place as a parable about the shape of authority. The authority Jaynes describes is perfectly *overt*: it has a voice, it issues commands, and a hearer knows exactly what is being asked of them. That is the oldest form of authority in the human repertoire and the one our equipment for obedience and disobedience was built for.

The death of the guarantee. Nietzsche's madman announces that God is dead, and the people who laugh at him have not understood what they have done (Nietzsche, 1882/2001, §125). Chapter 3 argues that what died was not belief but the *guarantee*. It was the assurance that values are found rather than made, underwritten by something outside human decision. After the guarantee goes, authority does not disappear. It migrates into successors that borrow its force while disowning its source. Nietzsche called these successors *shadows*.

The authority with no voice. Erich Fromm, writing in the twentieth century, named the form those shadows finally took: *anonymous authority* (Fromm, 1941, 1955). It is the authority of common sense, of the market, of what one does, of what is normal. It issues no commands, so it cannot be disobeyed. Alexis de Tocqueville had already sketched it a century earlier, as a mild, provident power that does not break the will but softens it, bends it and guides it (Tocqueville, 1840/2006, Vol. 2, Book 4, Ch. 6). Today its most visible form is the ranked feed, an arrangement that shapes what millions of people attend to and that no one can name an author for.

The practice. Wallace saw the late-twentieth-century version of this from inside American entertainment. He saw that irony had become the dominant cultural posture and that irony is superb at unmasking and useless at building (Wallace, 1993). His proposed answer, in the

commencement address published as *This Is Water*, was a discipline of attention, a choice about what to notice and how to construe it (Wallace, 2009). Watts, from a different direction, had argued that some states cannot be reached by trying, because effort produces their opposite (Watts, 1951). The map gave him the third stage as a cure: the dissolution of the “skin-encapsulated ego” into a sense of unity with everything. What this book keeps from Watts is the first idea, not the cure.

The provisional map ran from an origin to a crisis, a reorientation and a practice. This book keeps the first three stages, adds the stage the map lacked (the form authority took after the crisis), and corrects the last. Its central finding is that attention cannot be the last stage, because a *resolution* to attend is itself one of the reactions the problem is made of. The practice has to move out of the head and into the arrangements around it. Chapter 9 makes that argument, and the Conclusion redraws the map.

The argument in outline

Part One: The Condition. Chapter 1 argues that the strain of holding many catastrophes in view is routinely misnamed as cognitive dissonance. It is better described as a disproportion between assigned *responsibility* and available *efficacy*. Clinical ethics has studied this structure for forty years under the name *moral distress*. Chapter 2 asks why the culture’s only remedy for that strain is subtraction, and finds the answer in a civic vocabulary almost entirely built from prohibitions. Nietzsche’s parable of the camel, the lion and the child describes exactly this: the lion can win freedom by refusing, but it cannot create. Chapter 3 shows that Nietzsche’s two famous figures, the Last Man (the contented person who has stopped wanting anything difficult) and the Übermensch (the person who makes new values), are two responses to one situation. They differ by a single capacity, the capacity to make something, and the present looks less like the Last Man than like a nation of lions.

Part Two: The Mechanism. Chapter 4 identifies the mechanism the other pathologies depend on: the collapse of the interval between a stimulus arriving and a response leaving. Filling that interval is

rational, because the interval is where an undischageable obligation becomes present. Chapter 5 explains why nobody catches the collapse happening. An incorporated instrument does not appear in experience as an instrument. An instrument optimized against breakdown never becomes visible. And the sense of having chosen is assembled after the fact, from cues that an arrangement can supply.

Part Three: Two Counterfeits. Chapter 6 proposes that conspiracism is an attempt to convert anonymous authority into overt authority by supplying the missing agent, because an agent can be refused and a system cannot. The best evidence shows that the motives driving the belief are not satisfied by it, and the chapter explains why that failure deepens the belief instead of ending it. Chapter 7 turns the same analysis on the respectable critique of the attention economy. That critique is nearly universally accepted and almost entirely inert, and the chapter argues that this is a stable equilibrium rather than a stage on the way to change.

Part Four: Construction. Chapter 8 argues that tolerating an undischarged impulse and tolerating being bad at something belong to one family of capacities, and that construction requires them. Chapter 9 draws the practical consequence. Remedies must operate on arrangements rather than on states, and at the scale of a society that means norms. The chapter proposes twelve norms for a medium that has had only twenty-five years to develop any.

How to read the claims

The book makes three kinds of claim, and it helps to know which is which.

Structural claims are about how a mechanism works. They are argued from analysis and are not settled by any single study. The numbered propositions are mostly of this kind.

Empirical claims are about what the evidence shows. Each one cites its source, and each has a grade in Appendix C, which runs from *established* (replicated and consistent) to *speculative* (plausible but undemonstrated).

Interpretive claims are readings of texts. They are offered as the most defensible available readings, not as the only possible ones.

The rules this book keeps

Five rules govern the argument. They are stated here because the chapters rely on them.

1. **Every proposition can be wrong in a stated way.** For each one, Appendix D names the observation that would refute it. A claim that nothing could refute would not be an argument, and the book does not make claims of that kind.
2. **No agentless motives.** A sentence that gives wants to something that cannot want (“the market wants,” “the algorithm wants”) explains nothing. Chapter 6 argues that such sentences substitute for an explanation. Where this book describes a system, it says what the system is optimized on and with what effect, and it says so plainly where it cannot say who set the objective.
3. **Convergence is not corroboration.** When two thinkers working independently reach the same structure, the agreement is worth noting. It is not evidence that the structure is real, and the book never counts it as evidence.
4. **Quotations are verified or marked.** Every direct quotation in this book has been checked against a printed or authoritative source, or it is listed in Appendix E, by chapter, as unverified. Nietzsche is quoted from the public-domain translations of Common and Ludovici, which can be checked word for word; where the text paraphrases him, it cites the Cambridge Texts edition. Paraphrase is never dressed as quotation.
5. **The book is inside its own diagnosis.** An argument about hidden orders, disclosure and the reader who finally sees has the shape of what it diagnoses. Chapter 6 says that this shape does not sort by respectability. Falsifiers and evidence grades are the governor this book accepts in place of an exemption.

PART I

The Condition

The Condition, Named Wrongly

Why the weight of many catastrophes is not cognitive dissonance, and what it is instead

The strain of holding many civilization-scale threats in view is routinely called *cognitive dissonance*. The label is wrong in a way that matters, because it sends the analysis to a literature whose remedies all work by restoring consistency between beliefs, and that is not the problem here. This chapter argues that the strain is a disproportion between assigned *responsibility* and available *efficacy*. It is an obligation to hold a defensible position on an unbounded set of matters, combined with the capacity to affect almost none of them. The chapter separates three senses of *responsibility* to show which one has been detached and generalized. It shows that this structure already has a name and a measurement literature, in a field few people would think to consult. It corrects two adjacent constructs that most discussions reach for. And it derives the shrug as the correct output of a correct procedure, not as a failure of character.

Why “cognitive dissonance” is the wrong construct

Festinger’s (1957) theory concerns the discomfort of holding two inconsistent cognitions, or of acting against one’s own attitude. The engine of the theory is inconsistency, and every resolution it predicts restores consistency. A person under dissonance changes the belief, changes the behavior, adds a consonant cognition, or downgrades the importance of one element.

Now apply it. What is inconsistent about believing that nuclear war is possible, *and* that a pandemic is possible, *and* that the grid is fragile? Nothing. The beliefs are consistent with one another and all of them are defensible. A person who holds every one of them has made no logical error and is under no pressure toward consistency.

There is a second, sharper failure. Dissonance predicts that people will revise a belief, dropping or downgrading one of the inconsistent items. That is not what people do. They keep every belief and stop acting. Dissonance theory does not predict that, so it cannot be what explains it.

The mislabeling is not cosmetic. It licenses a remedy: get your beliefs in order, correct the distortion, put things in perspective. That remedy is addressed to a relation between cognitions. The actual relation is between a cognition and a capacity.

Four candidate explanations

A single explanation, held alone, is closer to an attachment than to a hypothesis. So here are four, including the unglamorous ones, because the unglamorous explanation is right more often than the interesting one.

H1: A finite pool of worry. Concern is a limited resource. Worry given to one threat is taken from another, and a person exposed to many threats worries about each one less (Weber, 2006). The hypothesis is intuitive and widely cited, but recent direct tests have been unkind to it. They suggest that what is finite is attention rather than worry, and that displacement effects are smaller and more conditional than the popular version implies (Sisco et al., 2023). Nothing in this book leans on H1.

H2: Probability neglect and scope insensitivity. People respond to the vividness of a catastrophic outcome more than to its probability, and they are insensitive to the size of the numbers describing it. Slovic's (2007) work on the identified victim and on psychic numbing is the strongest version. The asymmetry between a single named victim and a statistical one replicates well. The stronger claim, that feeling *declines* as numbers rise, is better evidenced for charitable giving than for threat response, and only the weaker version is used here.

H3: Media supply. On this view there is no psychological condition at all. What changed is the delivery system, not the citizen. An attention market selects for the most arousing available item, catastrophes are the most arousing items available, and the apparent multiplication of threats is an artifact of what gets surfaced. This explanation is substantially correct, and any account that ignores it is reasoning toward a conclusion it has already chosen. Much of what a person feels here is manufactured by supply. The only reason not to stop at H3 is a single prediction it gets wrong, which this chapter isolates below.

H4: Responsibility without efficacy. The citizen has been made *answerable* for holding a position on an unbounded set of threats, by a political culture in which having a view is the unit of participation. The same citizen has the capacity to *act* on almost none of them.

Agreement between a hypothesis and the evidence is cheap. The useful question is what one hypothesis forbids that another permits.

Table 1.1: What each explanation predicts (“yes”), cannot accommodate (“no”: it gives no reason to expect the observation, and on its own terms it should not occur) or is silent about (“–”).

Observation	H1	H2	H3	H4
Adding a threat reduces concern about the others	yes	–	–	–
Vivid low-probability items dominate high-harm ones	–	yes	yes	–
Distress falls when a person gains a concrete local role, beliefs unchanged	no	no	no	yes
Distress persists in low-consumption people holding the same beliefs	–	–	no	yes
Distress tracks the <i>number</i> of threats, not the severity of the worst	yes	–	–	yes

The third row does the decisive work, and it is where H4 would die if it were wrong. H4 predicts that giving a person a bounded, concrete, local responsibility they can actually discharge will reduce the distress without changing a single belief about the threats. H1 and H2 cannot accommodate that result, because on those accounts the problem lives in the beliefs and the beliefs have not changed. H3 cannot accommodate it either, because on that account the problem lives in the feed and the feed has not changed.

The inventory, side by side

An argument that insists on measurement cannot then wave vaguely at “existential risk,” and the finding below only becomes visible when the threats are set out in one table.

Start with the threat we can count. NASA’s Jet Propulsion Laboratory lists more than 42,000 known near-Earth objects in its Small-Body Database. Its Sentry system continuously evaluates every cataloged object’s chance of impact over the next century, and none currently rates above zero on the scale used to communicate impact hazard to the public (Center for Near-Earth Object Studies, 2026). The survey goal set for NASA in 1998, finding nine in ten of the kilometer-class objects capable of global catastrophe, is reported to have been met. Here is a civilization-ending threat with a known base rate, a dedicated agency, a budget and a published answer. The correct response for a citizen is that this is handled, the people handling it have said so, and attention belongs elsewhere.

Nobody feels that. The gap between what the evidence licenses and what a person feels on reading an asteroid headline is the cleanest available case of vividness overriding probability where the probability is actually known. It is also the reason the asteroid belongs on the list at all. It shows that the weight is not coming from the threats.

The threats we cannot count. Nuclear war, engineered pandemics, catastrophic AI outcomes, grid collapse and civil conflict have no base rate, because they are not repeated trials. What exists instead is expert judgment, and on unprecedented events that judgment is widely dispersed. The Existential Risk Persuasion Tournament put the same questions to 80 domain experts and 89 superforecasters and shows how far apart two kinds of credible judgment can sit. The median probability of human extinction by 2100 was 6 percent for the experts and 1 percent for the superforecasters. For extinction caused by artificial intelligence it was 3 percent and 0.38 percent (Karger et al., 2023). The report’s own table of published estimates for AI-caused extinction runs from 25 percent down to 0.38 percent, a spread of about sixtyfold, although the studies differ in definitions and time horizons. A dispersed estimate is not evidence for its high end. Quoting the highest credible figure as what “experts say” is the standard distortion

of catastrophe writing. It is an instance of what Kuran and Sunstein (1999) called an *availability cascade*, a self-reinforcing process in which a claim gains plausibility through repetition, and the repetition is driven by how arresting the claim is rather than by its support.

Climate is the distinctive case. It is settled in direction and magnitude, long in timescale, diffuse in agent and negligible in individual leverage. It therefore produces maximal responsibility with minimal efficacy, on a horizon no single life can close. If the central proposition of this chapter holds, climate should produce more distress per unit of expected harm than anything else on the list. That is a prediction worth testing.

Table 1.2: The threat inventory, compared on five dimensions.

Threat	Timescale	Base rate known	Responsible agent	Individual leverage
Asteroid	10^5 – 10^8 yr	Yes	Planetary defense	None, and none needed
Nuclear war	Hours, once begun	No	About nine governments	Effectively none
Pandemic	Months	Partly	Public health, global	Small, real, local
Climate	Centuries	In direction	Everyone and no one	Negligible alone
Artificial intelligence	Unknown	No	A few labs and states	None
Grid or financial collapse	Days	Partly	Utilities, regulators	None
Civil conflict	Years	No	Citizens, including you	Small, real, local

Three findings fall out of the table.

First, the timescales differ by six orders of magnitude. A response calibrated to one threat is absurd for another, and no schedule lets a person attend both to a threat measured in hours and to one measured in centuries.

Second, the responsible agent differs in every row, and in most rows it is not you. This is a fact about causal structure, not a moral observation. A civic culture that assigns every citizen a position on

every row has made most people responsible for things outside any causal path they occupy.

Third, exactly two rows carry nonzero individual leverage, and both are local. One is community-scale pandemic response. The other is civil conflict, which is the only civilization-scale threat on the list constituted by the aggregate ordinary conduct of ordinary people rather than by a government, a laboratory or a rock. The constructive half of this book is built on that row.

The mechanism: three kinds of responsibility

In ordinary use the word *responsibility* carries three different things, and the strain at issue is produced by a specific mismatch among them.

Causal responsibility. You are among the causes of the outcome. Your conduct made a difference to whether it happened.

Role responsibility. You occupy a position that assigns you a task with respect to the outcome, as the lifeguard is responsible for the swimmers or the auditor for the accounts. Role responsibility comes with a *jurisdiction*, which is a bounded domain, and a *completion condition*, which means something counts as having done the job.

Answerability. You are liable to be asked for your position on the matter and judged by your answer. Answerability demands the least of the three, and it turns out to be the heaviest to carry.

Ordinarily the three travel together, and that ordinary case is bearable because the other two bound the third. A person with role responsibility is answerable *for the role*, which is finite. A person with causal responsibility is answerable *for their contribution*, which can be specified. The answering has an end because the thing being answered for has edges.

For the modern citizen, answerability has been detached from both of the others and generalized. The citizen is answerable for a position on nuclear escalation without being among its causes or holding any office in relation to it. The same goes for a pathogen, a grid, a model, a court, a war and a famine. None of them is the citizen's doing and none is the citizen's office. The obligation to give an account has been extended across the whole inventory, and the two things that would have bounded it have been left behind.

Proposition 1 (*structural*). The distress produced by a catastrophic threat inventory is a function not of the threats' severity or of their inconsistency, but of the disproportion between the responsibility a citizen is assigned and the efficacy they possess.

In Proposition 1, "assigned responsibility" means answerability, the third sense above. This is the argument about pressure from Fromm's *Escape from Freedom* (1941), with one term substituted. Fromm's gap runs between the freedom a person has and the *self-strength* to use it. He held that this gap was the standing condition of modern life and that every "escape" he described was shaped to fit it. Here the gap runs between the responsibility a person has been given and the capacity to discharge it. The formal structure is the same, and so are the consequences. The pressure cannot be relieved by argument, because a belief did not produce it. Adding input can increase the pressure instead of relieving it. And the gap can be closed from either side, but the two sides are not equivalent (Chapter 2 says how they differ).

This also gives the precise reason the dissonance label fails. Dissonance is a relation between two cognitions. This is a relation between a cognition and a capacity. There is no pair of beliefs to bring into line, so every dissonance-style resolution is unavailable. You cannot change the belief, because it is true. You cannot change the behavior, because no behavior is available. You cannot add a consonant belief, because no belief supplies a missing capacity. And you cannot shrink the item's importance, because the item is a war. Dissonance comes with a resolution procedure. This condition comes with none, which makes it a different object rather than a stronger version of the same discomfort.

An obligation that can be neither discharged nor resigned

Two properties do the damage, and both follow from the detachment.

The obligation has no completion condition. Role responsibility can be discharged: the shift ends, the audit is filed, the person is released. Answerability without a role has no end point. No amount of attention, concern, reading or stated opinion counts as having *done* it, and the obligation renews continuously at a rate set by the reporting apparatus rather than by the world or by the person.

Nor can it be resigned. A role can be quit and a causal contribution can be withdrawn. Answerability, however, attaches to *being a member of the public*, and there is no procedure for ceasing to be one. The attempted resignation (“I don’t follow the news,” “I don’t do politics”) is not accepted by others or by the person. It is heard as a confession rather than a resignation, and it feels that way from the inside too.

An obligation that can be neither completed nor resigned is a specific kind of load. It may be the one item on the list of modern complaints that has no precedent at scale. Earlier generations were answerable for less, or answerable to a smaller public, or held roles that bounded what they answered for. Universal answerability for the whole of world affairs, with no office and no causal path, is new.

The construct already exists

This structure has been described, measured and studied for forty years. It is called *moral distress*, and it comes from nursing ethics.

Jameton’s (1984) original formulation is close to the structure above. Moral distress arises when a person knows the ethically right course of action but is prevented from taking it, by institutional structure, hierarchy, resource limits or law. The person is not confused about what ought to happen, and that is what separates moral distress from moral uncertainty and from an ordinary dilemma. The knowledge is intact and the capacity is missing.

The field has a validated instrument, the Moral Distress Scale and its revisions (Corley et al., 2001). It has documented correlates including burnout, disengagement and attrition. And the construct has spread well beyond nursing, into medicine, social work, teaching, veterinary practice, the military and environmental work. Its boundaries are debated, and some authors argue it has been stretched too far, but the core construct is well established.

Two things follow, and they point in opposite directions. The first concerns originality. “Responsibility without efficacy” is substantially the moral-distress construct, and this book’s contribution is the application: the claim that ordinary citizenship in an information-saturated polity now reproduces the structure nursing ethics identified in constrained clinicians. The second concerns testability, and here the

overlap is very good news. A construct with a validated instrument and a documented pattern of correlates is far more useful than a philosophical posit, and the decisive experiment proposed at the end of this chapter can be run with an existing scale.

Moral residue

The extension that matters most describes what happens across many episodes. Epstein and Hamric (2009) proposed that each unresolved episode leaves *moral residue*, the accumulated weight of having known the right thing and not done it. Residue does not clear between episodes, so each new episode begins from a higher baseline. Over a career this produces what they call a *crescendo effect*: distress rises with each cycle and ends either in withdrawal from the role or in a kind of numbing. The accumulation dynamics are less well tested than the base construct, but the fit to the citizen's case is uncomfortably close. Each item in the inventory arrives, is recognized as mattering, offers no available action, and is left behind. That leaves residue, and the next item lands on top of it.

The crucial difference from the clinical case is that the citizen's episodes have no shift boundary. There is no end of rotation, no closed case and no discharged patient. The supply is continuous and the residue never clears.

That predicts the two endpoints anyone can observe. One is *withdrawal*, which this chapter calls the shrug and declines to call apathy. The other is *numbing*, in which every belief is kept and the feeling is stripped out, leaving a portfolio of concerns held without commitment. Neither is a defect of character. Both are what the moral-distress literature predicts for a person in a role with unbounded demands and no discharge, and that literature was built by studying people whose competence and conscientiousness were never in question.

Two corrections from neighboring fields

Political efficacy, and the cell that matters

Political science distinguishes two kinds of efficacy (Craig et al., 1990). *Internal efficacy* is the belief that one is personally competent to under-

stand and take part in politics. *External efficacy* is the belief that the system responds, so that participation has effects.

The revealing combination is high internal efficacy with low external efficacy. This is a person who believes they understand the situation perfectly well and does not believe anything they do will register. The profile is associated with alienation rather than disengagement. It describes the informed, articulate, exhausted citizen, who can explain the mechanism in detail and does nothing, and who is routinely and wrongly diagnosed as lazy.

Proposition 1 is a claim about that profile specifically. This distress is not produced by ignorance, and information does not relieve it. That is why every remedy consisting of *more information* makes it worse, and why the person supplying the information experiences the recipient's exhaustion as ingratitude.

Helplessness is not learned; control is

The original theory of learned helplessness held that organisms exposed to uncontrollable aversive events *learn* that they are helpless, and that the learned passivity generalizes. It became one of the most cited ideas in psychology, and it is what most people mean when they gesture at civic passivity.

Maier and Seligman's (2016) reconsideration, informed by fifty years of neuroscience, inverts it. Passivity in the face of prolonged aversive events is not learned at all. It is the default response, mediated by brainstem circuits. What is learned is *control*: the detection that one's own responses affect outcomes, registered by circuits in the medial prefrontal cortex that then inhibit the default. Carrying a neural-circuit account over to human civic behavior is an extrapolation, and it is offered here as one. Even so, it changes the whole shape of the remedy.

If helplessness is learned, the task is to unlearn it. That means correcting a false belief, an argumentative and educational job, and it is what every exhortation assumes. If *control* is what is learned, passivity is not a pathology to be argued away but a baseline that has never been overridden. The only thing that overrides it is the actual experience of

one's responses mattering. The belief that they matter does not do it. The experience does.

That is why no argument fixes the condition and no quantity of information fixes it, and why the intervention Proposition 1 points to is a bounded, concrete, completable role rather than persuasion. The role is not a morale device. On the best current account, it is the input that overrides the default.

What the condition feels like, and where the misnaming comes from

The condition does not present itself as what it is, and that is where the misnaming starts.

It presents as guilt with no specifiable offense. The person feels they have failed at something and cannot name what. An undischargeable answerability would produce exactly that feeling, and it explains why the feeling survives every attempt to reason it away. With no offense to be acquitted of, acquittal is impossible.

It presents as urgency with no object, a standing sense that something should be happening *now*. Because that urgency attaches to no particular action, no action relieves it.

It presents as fatigue that rest does not cure. The load is not exertion, since nothing has been spent. What is present is an obligation held open, and holding something open is not a tiredness that sleep can reach.

Most misleadingly, it presents as being *about* the threats. That is why people describe it as climate anxiety, news fatigue or doom. Those labels place the problem in the content, which sends the remedy to the content: read less, care less, put it in perspective. The content is not the problem. The structure of the obligation is, and every remedy aimed at content leaves that structure untouched while adding one more increment of *freedom from*.

Proposition 2 (*structural*). Subtraction without provision widens the gap it was intended to close. An increment of *freedom-from*, delivered to a person short of *freedom-to*, increases the disproportion.

Where the media-supply account fails

This is the one place where H3, the strongest rival, makes a wrong prediction. H3 predicts that reducing exposure resolves the condition: cut the supply and the distress goes with it. People who substantially reduce their consumption do report real improvements in mood and sleep. The evidence here is weak and relies heavily on self-report. What it suggests is a much smaller improvement in the specific thing at issue, the sense of being answerable for a world one cannot affect.

Proposition 1 gives the reason. Removing the information does not remove the responsibility. A person who has stopped reading about a war is still a citizen of a country prosecuting one. The obligation was never carried by the news; the news only delivered the occasions. Remove the occasions and what remains is an unmet obligation with no content. That is worse, not better, and it accounts for the distinctly guilty flavor of a news fast.

The shrug, derived rather than deplored

Consider a citizen with a finite budget of attention facing n threats. Each threat presents as urgent. The threats share no common unit, so they cannot be traded against one another. Their timescales differ by orders of magnitude, so no schedule serves them all. The responsible agent differs for each threat and in most cases excludes the citizen. And n has no upper bound, because the supply of reportable catastrophe depends on the reporting apparatus rather than on the world.

What is the rational allocation? There is none. The problem is not that the choice is hard. An unbounded option set with incommensurable units and no dominance relation has no well-formed optimum. Any allocation is arbitrary, and an arbitrary allocation on a matter presented as urgent feels like a moral failure.

The shrug is what a well-formed procedure returns when the problem is ill-posed. It is not apathy and it is not stupidity. Above all, and this is the part that exhortation cannot afford to notice, it is not a defect of character. It is the correct output of a correct process working on an impossible input.

That has a consequence for any constructive proposal. A call to action addressed to a person in this position that does not change the

structure of their option set is asking them to be irrational on purpose. Most such calls do exactly that, which is why they fail and why the failure is then blamed on the audience. Only calls that bound the set can work. That is a design constraint, and it is what this chapter hands to everything constructive that follows. A proposal that does not reduce the option set to something completable will not work, and it should be rejected on that ground rather than on the ground that people are lazy.

What happens to the beliefs themselves

Take one threat. A belief about it generates a program: prepare, support the relevant institutions, learn the skills, organize locally. Take two threats with different agents and timescales, and the program does not double. It degrades, because the actions compete for one budget with no exchange rate between them. Take twelve, and the set of beliefs generates no program at all, and the citizen's relationship to their own convictions changes character.

The beliefs no longer guide action. They are *held*: items in a mental inventory, maintained for display, revisable in argument and causally inert with respect to conduct. This is Fromm's *having mode* arriving from an unexpected direction (Fromm, 1976), a portfolio of concerns in place of a set of commitments.

That explains something otherwise puzzling. The intensity of a person's expressed concern is uncorrelated with any change in their behavior, and this is not hypocrisy. The person is not failing to act on a belief. The belief never reached the position from which it could generate action, because the structure of the set prevented it.

Attention within the set is therefore allocated by something other than expected harm. It goes by feeling, vividness, narrative shape and identifiability, so attention to threats sorts by *story quality*. The asteroid, the one measurably handled item, has the best story: a single object, a date, a countdown, a rescue. Antibiotic resistance is a serious and genuinely tractable threat with real institutional and individual points of leverage, and it has no story at all. It has no villain, no date and no image, only a slow curve. Nobody stockpiles against the antibiotic

curve. That is not a failure of intelligence. It is the predictable output of an attention system working on a set it cannot rank.

One last construct needs refusing. It is tempting to explain all of this as *overload*: too much information, limited working memory, the mind as a saturated pipe. The metaphor predicts that reducing information restores function, which is H3's prediction, and it fails the same way. The obstacle was never the number of items held in memory. It was the absence of any decision procedure over incommensurable options combined with an absence of agency.

The problem is not that the citizen knows too much. It is that knowing has been made the unit of participation, and knowing is the one civic act that generates no obligation it can discharge.

The decisive experiment

Proposition 1 stands or falls on a single study that has not yet been run in the form needed. Give one group of people a bounded, concrete, completable civic responsibility, something small, local and genuinely theirs. Measure their threat-related distress against a control group, with their beliefs about the threats held constant and measured. Proposition 1 predicts that distress falls *even though the inventory is unchanged and the role is trivially small compared with the threats*. Because the moral-distress literature supplies a validated instrument, the study can be built from parts that already exist. Appendix D lists this experiment alongside the cheaper tests that bear on the same claim.

Where the argument goes next

If the citizen's condition is a gap between answerability and efficacy, the obvious question is why the culture's remedies all try to close it by removing things. Chapter 2 finds the answer in a civic vocabulary made almost entirely of prohibitions, and in a parable Nietzsche wrote about a lion.

CHAPTER 2

The Lion's Problem

Why a culture can dismantle anything and construct nothing, and why that is a stage rather than a flaw of character

American political vocabulary is, at its foundation, almost entirely negative. It is a grammar of prohibitions on power. That was a design achievement of the first order, and it is also only half of an equation. When the polity feels a crisis, it reaches for the tool it has, and the tool it has is subtraction.

Nietzsche gave the best available account of what happens when subtraction becomes a permanent stance. He wrote it nearly sixty years before Fromm, in the form of a parable. In the three metamorphoses of the spirit, the camel bears what it is given, the lion wins freedom by refusing, and only the child creates. Nietzsche presents the lion's inability to create as a structural limit, not a moral failing. This chapter argues that a culture stuck at the lion has maximal negative liberty and no capacity to make anything with it. It argues that this describes the contemporary United States better than accounts that reach straight for the Last Man. And it argues that the lion's position was genuinely earned and is not cowardly. The chapter ends by naming the hinge on which the rest of the book turns. The lion was made to fight a dragon with a face, and the authority it now faces has none (a point the end of this chapter develops).

Freedom from and freedom to

Fromm's distinction between two kinds of freedom is the most useful thing in his work and the most often flattened, so it needs to be stated precisely.

Negative freedom, or freedom *from*, is the removal of constraint. It means freedom from the primary ties of family, clan, land and inherited station, and from the authority that told a person what they were. It is genuine and worth having, and modernity delivered it in vast quantities.

Positive freedom, or freedom *to*, is the capacity to act from one's own nature, in what Fromm calls spontaneous activity, love and productive work (Fromm, 1941). It is not a quantity of options. It is a *capacity*, and it develops slowly, unevenly and only under supporting conditions.

Fromm's central historical claim is that modernity delivered enormous quantities of the first kind and almost none of the second. It dissolved the structures that told people who they were and put nothing in their place except the market, which is a structure of exchange, not of meaning.

His mechanism runs like this. Individuation cuts primary ties one at a time, and each cut delivers two things at once: an increment of independence and an increment of aloneness. Meanwhile *self-strength*, the actual capacity to act from one's own center, develops slowly. The gap between the freedom a person has and the strength to use it is the standing condition of modern life, and every escape Fromm describes is shaped to fit that gap.

Three consequences follow. Increasing freedom can increase the pressure to escape instead of relieving it. Argument cannot relieve the pressure, because a belief did not produce it. And the gap can be closed from either side, but the two sides are not equivalent. You can reduce the freedom, which every institution of submission has offered and which works, at the cost of the very thing that made the person a person. Or you can increase the strength.

Reading the Bill of Rights as a grammar

The founding American statement of liberty is a list of prohibitions on government. *Congress shall make no law. Shall not be infringed. No soldier shall ... be quartered. Shall not be violated. Nor shall be compelled.*

This is not a criticism. The negative form is exactly why the document has lasted. A prohibition on power can be enforced in a way a positive entitlement cannot, the framers understood that, and much of the world's later constitutional practice borrowed the form because it works.

Read it as a grammar, though, and the pattern is unmistakable. The American political vocabulary for liberty is, at its root, a vocabulary of *from*. Nearly the whole lexicon a citizen inherits for talking about freedom is negative in Fromm's exact sense: rights, protections, immunities, limits, checks, government off your back, the right to be left alone.

The matching vocabulary for *freedom to* is thin, borrowed and contested. "The pursuit of happiness" is the closest the founding documents come, and it is a *pursuit* rather than a capacity, a permission to seek rather than a competence to exercise. Everything else in the positive register arrived later, from outside the constitutional tradition, and has been fought over ever since precisely because it does not fit the grammar. That includes the New Deal's freedoms from want and from fear, two of the Four Freedoms that had to be phrased negatively to be heard at all. It also includes the civic-republican language of virtue and participation, and the long argument over positive rights.

This is an interpretive claim. It is offered as the most defensible reading of the record, not as a fact the record forces.

The consequence is symmetric

A polity fluent in what it must not be subjected to, and inarticulate about what it is for, has a predictable failure mode. When it feels a crisis, it reaches for the tool it has. Look at the shape of American responses to a felt loss of control, across the political spectrum:

- Deregulate: remove the constraint.
- Defund: remove the institution.

- Secede, exit, homeschool, unplug, go off-grid, move to a state that leaves you alone: remove yourself.
- Detox, unsubscribe, delete the account, log off: remove the input.
- Cancel, block, mute, ban: remove the person.

The list deliberately mixes items that belong to opposed coalitions. The coalitions differ on *what* should be removed and agree completely that removal is the form a remedy takes. That agreement is the deep structure, and it is invisible from inside either coalition, because each sees only the other side's subtractions.

Every move on the list is an increment of *freedom from*, and each is defensible in a particular case. Delivered to a person or a polity short of *freedom to*, each one widens the gap. Chapter 1 stated the principle as Proposition 2: subtraction without provision widens the gap it was intended to close.

The claim has a limit, stated so that it is not read as more than it is. Removing a bad constraint is not bad. Some constraints should go, and removing them is an unambiguous good. The claim is that a culture whose only well-developed political move is removal will apply removal when it faces a problem that requires construction, and will then experience the resulting decline as evidence that it did not remove enough. That is a loop.

The historical instances share a structure, and naming the structure is more useful than judging the cases, which would take another book and make this one partisan. A constraint was removed for good reasons. The function it had been performing was not provided for. The vacancy was then filled by something less accountable than what was removed. The pattern recurs in deregulation and deinstitutionalization, in the hollowing of local newspapers and civic gatekeeping, in the removal of editorial control and of professional licensure, and in the weakening of party discipline and the mainline church. Each removal had a real case behind it, each left a function unprovided, and in each something moved into the space that is harder to hold to account than what left.

The three metamorphoses

Thus Spoke Zarathustra opens its first part with “On the Three Metamorphoses”: the spirit becomes a camel, the camel becomes a lion, and the lion becomes a child (Nietzsche, 1883–1885/2006). It is the most underused passage in Nietzsche for the purposes of this argument.

The camel

The camel is the load-bearing spirit. It kneels and asks to be loaded, it wants the heaviest burden, its reverence is real, and its strength is measured by what it can carry. Its governing word is *Thou shalt*. The dragon it will eventually meet is covered in scales, and every scale is a value that has already been declared.

The camel is not a figure of contempt, and reading it as one is the first available mistake. It has genuine virtues: endurance, reverence, discipline and the willingness to be humbled for the sake of something. A culture with no camel phase has no inheritance to work with. That matters because the modern temptation is to believe one can begin as a lion.

The camel's limit is precise. It is strong, and it is not free. Everything it carries was given to it.

The lion

The lion's task is stated with total clarity. It is to become master of its own desert, to seize freedom, and to say a holy No even to duty. It faces the dragon *Thou shalt* and answers it with *I will*. It fights not for a new value but for the *right* to values. Then Nietzsche says the thing this book is named for:

To create new values—that, even the lion cannot yet accomplish: but to create itself freedom for new creating—that can the might of the lion do. (Nietzsche, 1883–1885/1909, “The Three Metamorphoses”)

Read against Fromm, the correspondence is exact. The lion *is* negative freedom. Its entire accomplishment is the removal of an authority, and that accomplishment is genuine, necessary, hard-won and not to be sneered at. Its power is the power to refuse, and Nietzsche presents the limit on that power as structural rather than moral: it does not extend to making anything.

The lion is the American grammar made into a figure.

The child

The third metamorphosis is the least quoted and the worst understood. Its terms are peculiar and precise:

Innocence is the child, and forgetfulness, a new beginning, a game, a self-rolling wheel, a first movement, a holy Yea. (Nietzsche, 1883–1885/1909, “The Three Metamorphoses”)

Every term is doing work. Readers who know Walter Kaufmann’s translation will remember the last phrase as “a sacred Yes.”

Innocence does not mean naivety. It means the absence of the resentment the lion’s fight necessarily produced. The lion had to fight, and fighting leaves a residue, an identity built from what one is against. The child is what remains once that residue is gone.

Forgetting is the capacity to stop carrying the argument with the dragon. The lion is still, in a sense, defined by *Thou shalt*, because *I will* is its negation.

A *game* is activity undertaken for its own sake. Aristotle’s *energeia*, activity complete in its own exercise, and Fromm’s spontaneous activity arrive at the same place from opposite directions.

A *self-rolling wheel* is a motion whose source is internal. It is positive freedom stated as an image: acting from one’s own center, not in reaction to something.

A *holy Yea* is the affirmation that constitutes something, not agreement with what is given. In the same passage the spirit now wills its own will and wins its own world.

On this account, creation is not available to the refusing spirit. It becomes available only after refusal has done its work and been let go.

Proposition 3 (*interpretive*). The three metamorphoses are a developmental sequence in which negative freedom is a necessary but strictly intermediate stage. The stage cannot be occupied permanently without pathology, because its defining act, refusal, is defined by the authority it refuses.

The diagnosis

A culture stuck at the lion has maximal negative liberty and no capacity to make anything with it.

It is not decadent in any trivial sense. It is not weak and it is not stupid. It is strong in exactly one direction. It can dismantle anything and construct nothing, and it experiences each successful dismantling as progress, because refusal is the only competence it has and so the only thing that looks like an achievement.

Nor can it move on to the child. The third metamorphosis requires letting go of the fight, and a spirit whose whole identity is the fight experiences letting go as annihilation rather than growth.

Why the lion's stage is so hard to leave

This needs to be said sympathetically, because an account that treats it as a failure of nerve has not understood it.

The lion's No was earned. It was won against a real dragon, and each scale on that dragon was a value that turned out to serve someone's interest, as the lion discovered the hard way. The refusal is not a posture. It is a conclusion supported by evidence, namely the record of the last sixty years of American institutional life.

So any invitation to move past refusal reads, from the inside, as an invitation to be fooled again. To a spirit with only two categories, the child's holy Yea looks exactly like the camel's *Thou shalt*. That is the structural reason the American political conversation cannot get past negation. The only visible alternative to refusing looks like submitting, and submission is what refusal was won against.

Nietzsche's answer is that the child's Yea is not a return to the camel's burden. It is a *first movement*, available only to a spirit that has passed *through* the lion rather than around it. He does not say how the passage is made. Part Four of this book takes up that question, and its answer concerns capacity rather than resolve.

Where refusal is enough

Fairness requires one more point, and the argument is weaker without it. There are domains where refusal is the right and complete answer, and treating the lion as a stage to outgrow would be a serious error in them. Examples are a citizen refusing to take part in a lie, a professional refusing to sign something false, and a person refusing an arrangement that would make them treat someone as an instrument.

These are not incomplete acts waiting for a constructive phase. They are finished acts, and they are the highest thing a person can do at the moment they are required. On Fromm's reading of Genesis, the founding human act is disobedience. The capacity to say no is the faculty that makes a person separate enough to have any other virtue at all (Fromm, 1966).

The claim is narrower. A life or a polity organized around refusal as its *standing* mode cannot construct, and the situations now facing the United States are overwhelmingly problems of construction.

A test anyone can run

Ask an American what they are against and you will get twenty minutes. Ask what they are for and you will get a negation of something else.

Try it on any contested issue. Pressed for a positive account, the answers on both sides resolve into *not that*: not that regulation, not that curriculum, not that immigration regime, not that platform, not that party, not that elite. The positive content is thin. That is not because people are thoughtless. It is because the vocabulary they inherited has thirty words for removing constraints and about four for building, and all four are contested.

The diagnosis predicts something else that can be checked. A coalition organized around a No should dissolve once the No succeeds, because it has no second act. A polity with a strong positive-freedom tradition, facing the same threats and the same information environment, should show materially less of the paralysis. Appendix D sets out both tests.

A lion with no dragon

One more step turns this from a diagnosis into the engine of the rest of the book.

The lion's refusal needs a dragon. *Thou shalt* is a command, and a command has an author. Nietzsche's lion is equipped for exactly that kind of authority, the kind Jaynes's bicameral hearer met as a voice and that a child meets in a parent or a worker in a boss. It is overt authority: an identifiable agent issuing an identifiable command, recognisable *as*

authority and therefore open to resentment, argument, resistance and disobedience.

Fromm saw that modern authority had changed shape, and he described the change across *Escape from Freedom* (1941) and, most sharply, *The Sane Society* (1955). Beside overt authority there is now *anonymous authority*. It has no agent. It works as common sense, as science, as public opinion, as what one does, as what is normal, as the market, as necessity. Fromm's point is that this is not a weaker form of authority but a stronger one. The boss is replaced by the impersonal requirements of the organization and the father's command by the expectations of one's peers. The person subject to it does not experience themselves as obeying, because there is nobody visible to obey.

Proposition 4 (*structural*). Anonymous authority cannot be disobeyed, because it never commanded anything. There is no face to defy, no order to refuse and no relationship within which refusal would make sense. It does not tell you what to do; it tells you what *is done*.

Tocqueville described the shape of this power a century before Fromm named it, at the close of *Democracy in America*. He pictured an immense, tutelary power, absolute, minute, regular, provident and mild. It covers the surface of society with a network of small, complicated rules. It seldom forces anyone to act, but it constantly restrains people from acting. It does not shatter the will; it softens it, bends it and guides it (Tocqueville, 1840/2006, Vol. 2, Book 4, Ch. 6). The rules in that picture are not issued by anyone a citizen could name. They are restraints with no restrainer. Mildness is why it provokes no resistance. Providence is why it is experienced as a service rather than as rule. And because it works as a network rather than through a commander, there is no one to defy.

Now put the pieces together. A culture whose only well-developed competence is refusal faces conditions in which the operative authority cannot be refused. The threats in Chapter 1's inventory share the property that matters: there is no one to refuse. Refusal does not disappear when its object does. It goes looking for the nearest refusable thing, and the nearest refusable thing is usually other people.

Chapter 3 follows the same structure into a second register, Nietzsche's fork between the Last Man and the Übermensch. Part Two asks

why the collapse of that search into reflex goes unnoticed by the people it happens to. Part Three shows where the search for a refusable object ends.

Nietzsche's Two Roads

The Last Man and the Übermensch are not two diagnoses. They are two responses to one situation, and the difference between them is a capacity

Nietzsche is the writer most often invoked in discussions of civilisational decline, and most often invoked wrongly, as a prophet who saw it coming. He was doing something else. He specified the conditions under which a value system fails and the order in which the failure unfolds. A specification of conditions can be checked against a present without anyone claiming its author foresaw that present. That distinction separates a checkable argument from an unfalsifiable prophecy, and this chapter attempts only the first.

Its central claim is structural and, I think, under-noticed. The Last Man and the Übermensch are not two diagnoses of two different situations. They are the two available responses to one situation, diagnosed correctly. Both arise after the guarantee is gone, and both presuppose that values are made rather than found. They differ entirely in whether a person keeps the capacity to make something. Assessed against that specification, the contemporary United States is not mainly on the Last Man's road. The diagnosis that fits is the one Chapter 2 drew from the same author: a nation of lions.

What died

The madman's announcement in *The Gay Science* is not an atheist's celebration, though it is often read as one. The madman is *seeking* God. The people who meet him with laughter already do not believe, and

his message is that they have not understood the size of what they have done. The imagery is of disorientation, not liberation:

Who gave us the sponge to wipe away the whole horizon? What did we do when we loosened this earth from its sun? ... Do we not stray, as through infinite nothingness? (Nietzsche, 1882/1910, §125)

What he reports is a deed, not a discovery: "God is dead! God remains dead! And we have killed him!" (Nietzsche, 1882/1910, §125). Nobody found out that God does not exist. Something was done, over centuries, and the doing was not deliberate.

Nietzsche also identifies who did it. Across §357 of *The Gay Science* and the late works, his claim is that Christianity was destroyed by its own morality, specifically by the will to truth it had cultivated, which eventually turned on its own foundations and found them wanting (Nietzsche, 1882/2001, §357). The tradition's highest value consumed the tradition. That was not a triumph of outside criticism. It was internal and self-inflicted, and on Nietzsche's account it was unavoidable.

What died, then, was not belief. It was the *guarantee*, the assurance that values are found rather than made and are underwritten by something outside human decision.

That distinction does most of the work in what follows, and it is why the usual debate about secularization misses the point. A population can keep its beliefs and still have lost the guarantee, and that is the present situation. Most people still report belief, and almost nobody argues for a value in any currency other than the one everyone else is using.

The shadows

An earlier section of the same book supplies the image:

God is dead: but as the human race is constituted, there will perhaps be caves for millennia yet, in which people will show his shadow. (Nietzsche, 1882/1910, §108)

Nietzsche did not expect a vacancy to appear and be felt as one. He expected it to be occupied by successors that borrow the authority of what died while disowning its source. The nineteenth and twentieth centuries obliged with nation, race, party, History, progress, the market and scientism. Scientism here means not science, which is a method with a self-correcting apparatus, but the position that scientific

authority can settle questions of value. Each successor occupied the place of a guarantee, and each was, in Nietzsche's terms, a shadow.

Each has also now been found out in most Western populations, through an ordinary process of institutional disappointment that required no philosophy at all. That point deserves emphasis. The present condition is not the product of anyone reading Nietzsche. It is the product of people watching institutions behave.

The first road

Nietzsche distinguishes two responses to the discovery, and the distinction is less evaluative than it looks. *Active nihilism* is the destructive stage that clears ground, a strength that attacks exhausted values because it has the power to. *Passive nihilism* is the exhaustion in which the highest values devalue themselves, no answer is sought, and the question is lowered until it stops hurting.

The Last Man is passive nihilism made into a figure, in the Prologue of *Zarathustra*. He has discovered happiness, he says, and he blinks. He has his little pleasures for the day and his little pleasures for the night, with due regard for health. He becomes neither poor nor rich: "both are too burdensome" (Nietzsche, 1883–1885/1909, Prologue §5). Nobody rules and nobody obeys, for the same reason. People still quarrel but are soon reconciled, because otherwise it upsets the stomach. Anyone who feels differently goes voluntarily into the madhouse.

The moment that matters is not the description. It is the crowd's response. Zarathustra offers the Last Man as a warning, and the people interrupt him: "Give us this last man, O Zarathustra ... make us into these last men!" (Nietzsche, 1883–1885/1909, Prologue §5). They ask for him by name.

That is the sharpest thing in Nietzsche for present purposes, and it is why the Last Man is not a catastrophe that happens to a population. He is a stable equilibrium that a population maintains and would choose again.

His defining phrase, repeated, is *too burdensome*. He is not evil, stupid or deceived. The Last Man has made an accurate calculation about the cost of caring and concluded, correctly on his own terms,

that it is not worth paying. Any argument that treats him as simply mistaken has not met him.

The second road

The *Übermensch* needs more care than the Last Man. The term has been ruined by a century of misuse, and Nietzsche himself says much less about it. That reticence is significant in itself, not a gap to fill in on his behalf. Four misreadings have to be cleared away.

It is not a biological or racial type. The Nazi appropriation ran through Elisabeth Förster-Nietzsche's editorial control of her brother's unpublished notes. It was a documented falsification, not an interpretation (Kaufmann, 1974). Nietzsche's own texts are contemptuous of German nationalism and of antisemitism, and his break with Wagner was substantially over them.

It is not a superior individual in the ordinary sense, such as a genius or a conqueror. Nietzsche admires many individuals and never identifies any of them as the *Übermensch*.

It is not a state one reaches and then possesses. Zarathustra calls the human being a rope over an abyss, and says that what is lovable in a human is that it is a going-across and a going-under, a transition and not a destination (Nietzsche, 1883–1885/2006, Prologue §4). A reading that makes the *Übermensch* an achievable status turns it into a possession, which is the thing Nietzsche most consistently opposes.

It is not mainly a doctrine about other people. Most contemporary uses of the word rank persons. The text uses it as an orientation for the self, and the orientation is self-overcoming, of what one currently is.

What it actually names

Three properties remain, and each has a text behind it.

Creation rather than reception. The defining act is the making of values. That is only possible once the guarantee has gone, so the project is specifically post-collapse rather than nostalgic. The death of God is the precondition of the *Übermensch*, not its obstacle. This reverses the usual reading, in which Nietzsche mourns something. He does not. The disorientation of §125 is the price of an opportunity, not the report of a loss.

Affirmation. The test is *amor fati* (love of fate) and the thought experiment of eternal recurrence: could you will this life, unchanged in every detail, endlessly? Nietzsche offers recurrence chiefly as a *criterion*, a test of whether a life is one's own, rather than as a cosmology. It is brutal, and it is the exact inverse of the Last Man's calculation. The Last Man asks what is too burdensome. The recurrence test asks what you would carry forever.

Self-overcoming, continuously. This means neither perfection nor arrival. The rope over the abyss is not crossed once and finished with.

The structural point

Here is the claim this chapter exists to make. The Last Man and the Übermensch are two responses to the same situation. Both arise after the guarantee has gone, both presuppose that values are made rather than found, and the difference lies entirely in what is done with that.

The Last Man draws one conclusion: *if nothing is underwritten, nothing is worth the cost, so minimize the cost*. That is a coherent inference. It is why he cannot be argued out of it, and why every exhortation addressed to him fails. His position is not an error.

The Übermensch draws the other: *if nothing is underwritten, creation is both possible and necessary, and I am the only available author*.

The fork, then, is not between belief and unbelief, or between optimism and pessimism. It is between two responses to an identical and correctly diagnosed situation, and the responses differ in whether the person still has the capacity to make something.

This is Fromm's distinction arriving in a second vocabulary. Freedom *from* the guarantee is where both roads begin. The Last Man is what happens when freedom *to* is absent, when the removal has happened and the capacity has not developed. Two philosophers, nearly sixty years apart and neither citing the other, describe one fork in two languages. By the rules this book keeps, their agreement is worth noting and is not evidence. The evidence lies in whether the fork predicts anything, and it does.

Where the trajectory points

This genre usually goes wrong at this point by predicting. The better course is to grade the conditions instead, one at a time.

The guarantee has gone. This is not an atheist claim, since a majority still report belief. It is a claim about the background of public argument. The assumption that values are underwritten by something outside human decision is no longer the default, even among believers, who now argue for their values in the same currency as everyone else.

The shadows have been found out. Nation, party, progress, market and expert authority have each undergone serial and largely justified disillusionment within living memory. Gallup's nine institutions, tracked consistently since 1979, averaged 28 percent in its July 2025 survey confidence ("a great deal" or "quite a lot"). That is near the lowest reading in forty-six years of measurement, and the average has stayed under 30 percent for four years running (Brenan, 2025). The same report adds a qualification. The average is stable only in aggregate. Republicans' and Democrats' confidence swings with which party holds the presidency, and the 11-point gap between them is the largest in the series. Confidence is low overall, and for partisans it follows control of the White House. Independents are the informative exception. Their average, 25 percent, has stayed statistically level for three years whoever holds the White House, a standing refusal of the kind the lion diagnosis predicts. The partisans' swings fit it less well. They look more like loyalty to the party in power, the group narcissism of Chapter 4, which is a different mechanism that this diagnosis does not explain.

Passive nihilism is widespread. This is the claim most often asserted and least often shown. Some evidence points toward it: declining participation, declining trust, and a rising expectation that public claims are made in bad faith. But it sits alongside strong evidence of intense, sustained and costly engagement by very large numbers of people. An account that reports only the disengagement is selecting its data, and much writing in this area does exactly that.

The Last Man's specific signature is present only in part. The clause about reconciling quickly for the sake of digestion is plainly false of the present, which is conflictual to a degree the Last Man would

find intolerable. A figure defined by the avoidance of quarrel does not describe a population that quarrels constantly and at cost.

That last observation decides the matter. The United States is not mainly on the Last Man's road. The Last Man is defined by avoiding burden, dissolving conflict and keeping a contented, blinking, well-regulated peace. The present is defined by an enormous expenditure of energy, sustained conflict, and many people carrying burdens they did not have to pick up.

What fits instead is the other figure from the same author. The energy is real, the refusal is real, and in many cases the courage is real, but almost none of it is construction. The dominant civic act is the No: to a party, an institution, a class of persons, a proposal, a narrative. The lion's competence is at a historical high, and the child's is not visibly present.

The Last Man is a spirit that never became a lion. What is present now is the opposite problem: a nation of lions, superbly equipped to refuse, in a situation that requires construction.

The lion's stage does not end well by itself

Nietzsche's sequence has the lion pass into the child, but he offers no mechanism by which it must. A lion that cannot make the third metamorphosis has two possible endings. One is exhaustion into the Last Man, when refusal finally costs more than it returns and *too burdensome* becomes true of the fight itself. The other is the reinstatement of a camel's burden supplied by whoever offers one. That is the authoritarian outcome, and Fromm wrote a whole book about it.

Both endings are possible, but the likeliest outcome is neither of them. It is *prolongation*: an arrangement that does not resolve, does not break and does not improve. It is sustained indefinitely because the lion's refusal is genuinely sufficient to block any construction, including the constructions that would be bad. A collapse at least creates the conditions for a revaluation. Prolongation produces nothing but more of itself.

Part Two asks how a population of lions sustains that prolongation without noticing it, and the answer begins with what happens in the second or two between a stimulus and a response.

PART II

The Invisible Mechanism

The Reactive Discharge

The collapse of the interval between a stimulus arriving and a response leaving, and why filling that interval is rational

Nearly every pathology of contemporary attention needs one mechanism in order to run, and Nietzsche named it in 1888. In *Twilight of the Idols* he wrote that “weakness of will, or more strictly speaking, the inability not to react to a stimulus, is in itself simply another form of degeneracy” (Nietzsche, 1889/1911, “Morality as the Enemy of Nature,” §2). A few pages later he describes the opposite capacity, the one he thought an education should build:

To learn to see—to accustom the eye to calmness, to patience, and to allow things to come up to it; to defer judgment ... One must not respond immediately to a stimulus ... All lack of intellectuality, all vulgarity, arises out of the inability to resist a stimulus:—one must respond or react, every impulse is indulged. (Nietzsche, 1889/1911, “Things the Germans Lack,” §6)

This chapter calls the failure Nietzsche describes the *reactive discharge*, and argues that it is the right target. It sits upstream of the other mechanisms, it is exactly what an engagement-optimized apparatus selects for, it happens at a scale an individual can reach, and every constructive act presupposes its opposite. The chapter also separates this claim from one it resembles: this is not an argument for calm. And it makes the argument that most changes what a remedy can be. The filled interval is not idle amusement. It is an effective and rationally chosen anesthetic, which is why every proposal simply to consume less tends to make things worse.

Four reasons the interval is the target

It is upstream of the others. A person facing a situation they cannot refuse refuses the nearest refusable thing, and that is a discharge. The authoritarian character's need for an enemy is a discharge. Reflexive defense of one's group is a discharge. Ungoverned myth-making requires a stimulus to be *interpreted* before it can be *examined*, which is a discharge dressed up as insight. And holding a dozen incommensurable threats in mind without collapsing them into one story is exactly what the discharge prevents. Interrupt the discharge and every one of these loses its supply.

It is what the apparatus is actually optimized to produce. A system that selects for engagement is, by definition, selecting for stimuli that get *reacted to*. It iterates against a model of one particular person until it finds the configurations that reliably produce a discharge. Its main product is not distraction. Distraction is what a person notices afterwards. The product is the shortened interval, and distraction is the by-product. No intent is needed for this. A function optimized on a measurable target, over a very large number of iterations, against a good model of one person, will find whatever most efficiently converts attention into the metric. The finding is made by search, not by decision.

It happens at a scale an individual can reach. Nobody confronts an anonymous, agentless system on a Thursday afternoon. The discharge, by contrast, happens dozens or hundreds of times a day, in units of a second or two, in circumstances entirely inside one person's situation. Of all the mechanisms named in this book it is the only one that is both upstream and local.

Every constructive act presupposes its opposite. Reading a long argument means letting several hundred impulses go undischarged. Building a capacity means tolerating being bad at something, which is undischarged frustration repeated. Deliberating means not concluding yet. Meeting another person means not converting them into an assessment on arrival. Refusing something at a cost requires the interval in which refusal becomes possible at all. The interval is not one virtue among several. It is the condition of the others.

What this is not

This is not an argument for calm, equanimity or a lower emotional temperature. The distinction matters, because the wellness reading of this material is both common and wrong.

The interval is not tranquility. A person can be furious and not discharge the fury. That is what a considered response to something genuinely outrageous consists of, and it demands more than serenity does, not less. What matters is the *gap*, not the temperature. A culture in which the gap has closed will produce both more rage and less anger than anyone acts on well. Those are not in tension; they are the same fact.

Wallace, used three ways

David Foster Wallace watched this develop from inside American entertainment and left three kinds of material. Each has to be used differently, under one rule. Fiction is not evidence: it supplies structure and vocabulary, and claims about the world need something else.

The novel supplies a structure

The central device of *Infinite Jest* is a film so entertaining that anyone who watches it keeps watching until they die, having lost interest in everything else, eating included (Wallace, 1996). Three features matter, and they are more precise than the ordinary complaint about media addiction.

Nobody is coerced. The Entertainment overpowers no one. It is simply better than the alternatives, and the viewer keeps choosing it. The horror lies entirely in a free choice made over and over. That is why the novel is a better instrument than any account of manipulation: it removes the villain, and the phenomenon survives.

The failure lies in the will's object, not its strength. The viewers are not weak-willed in the ordinary sense. Their will is intact and pointed at the Entertainment. What has failed is the capacity to want something else, which is a capacity and not a quantity of resolve. Every remedy aimed at willpower is aimed at the wrong faculty.

It kills by omission. The Entertainment harms no one directly. It occupies the interval in which the viewer would have done something else, and the something else was eating. That is the structure this chapter needs: nothing is done to you; an interval is filled.

The essay can be argued with

“E Unibus Pluram” is a different kind of document, written to be argued with (Wallace, 1993). Its thesis is that television absorbed the irony first used against it. Irony began as a critical instrument, a way of exposing the gap between what is presented and what is the case. It was then adopted by the presenting apparatus itself, which now performs self-awareness in advance. An advertisement that mocks advertising cannot be criticized for being an advertisement.

Wallace’s conclusion is the one that matters here: irony is excellent at unmasking and useless at building. It can strip away a pretension and cannot supply anything in its place. Its critical power is entirely negative.

Wallace’s diagnosis of American culture in 1993 and Nietzsche’s parable of the lion in 1883 identify the same limit from completely different directions. Each describes a competence for refusal that cannot create, and that becomes a prison precisely because it is so good at what it does. Wallace’s proposed successor was a willingness to be sincere, sentimental and uncool, and therefore open to mockery. It is the same move in a literary register, and Wallace was candid that he had not solved the problem.

The interviews supply a warning about pleasure

In conversation with David Lipsky in 1996, Wallace described where solitary consumption was heading:

It’s gonna get easier and easier, and more and more convenient, and more and more pleasurable, to be alone with images on a screen, given to us by people who do not love us but want our money. (Lipsky, 2010)

Note the structure of the warning. It is not about coercion. It is about convenience and pleasure, which is the same structure as the novel.

The prohibition on the unfilled interval

Take the observation seriously on its own terms. Where in ordinary life is an interval allowed to stay unfilled?

The elevator has music. The waiting room has a screen. The gas pump has a screen. The supermarket aisle has music, and so does the restaurant. The gym has both. The airport gate has a screen. The pause between a query and its answer is filled with a loading animation designed to make the pause feel shorter. The intervals the built environment has not colonized, such as the checkout line, the walk and the minutes before sleep, are filled by the phone, by default, without anyone deciding to fill them.

Proposition 7 (*structural*). A culture that fills every interval by default has not made a choice about entertainment. It has made a choice about the unfilled interval: that it is a defect to be remedied rather than a condition to be occupied.

The interval is genuinely aversive

This matters. If the unfilled interval were neutral, the fill would be mere convenience, and the remedy really would be to remove it.

Wilson et al. (2014) asked people to sit alone in a bare room for six to fifteen minutes with nothing to do but think. Participants rated the experience unenjoyable and found it hard to concentrate. The study's most discussed condition is something else. In it, many participants, and a majority of the men, gave themselves an electric shock they had earlier said they would pay to avoid rather than keep sitting with their thoughts. That result is widely over-cited and its interpretation is genuinely disputed, so it serves here only as an illustration. The core finding needs no help from it.

Killingsworth and Gilbert's (2010) experience-sampling study points the same way from another direction. Minds wander during a large share of waking time, and wandering goes with lower reported happiness.

Together these support a modest and sufficient conclusion: the unfilled interval is not neutral, and for many people it is actively unpleasant. A technology that reliably removes it is not selling a luxury. It is selling relief from a real aversive state.

Why consuming less often fails

What actually arrives in an unfilled interval, for a person carrying an unbounded set of obligations they cannot discharge? Not information, which is old by then. What arrives is the unresolved obligation, which has no available discharge. The interval is where the disproportion described in Chapter 1, between what one is answerable for and what one can do, stops being abstract.

So the interval is not merely boring. It is where the condition becomes present, and the fill is not idle amusement but an effective, rationally chosen anesthetic.

That is why proposals simply to consume less so often fail, and why they fail in a particular way. They remove the anesthetic without treating the condition. Proposition 2 applies directly: subtraction without provision widens the gap it was meant to close. A person who deletes the apps and does nothing else has arranged to spend more time in direct contact with an obligation that cannot be resolved, and will report, accurately, that it made things worse. That report is usually read as a sign of addiction or of weak commitment. It is neither. It is an accurate observation about what the intervention did.

None of this makes reducing consumption worthless. It improves real things, including mood and sleep. It does not touch the specific condition, and presenting it as though it does sets people up to experience an accurate result as a personal failure.

The loop

The discharge does not work alone. Its interaction with two of Fromm's mechanisms is what makes it politically consequential rather than merely personal.

The authoritarian pair. Fromm's authoritarian character is not primarily aggressive or primarily submissive. It is both, in one structure: a longing to submit to something larger and to dominate something smaller (Fromm, 1941). These are not opposites. They are one solution to one problem, eliminating the isolated self by fusing with others, upward and downward. Fusion upward supplies missing agency by borrowing it. Fusion downward supplies missing efficacy by exercising it on someone within reach.

Group narcissism is how this reaches ordinary people who would be horrified to be called authoritarian (Fromm, 1964). A person of no particular standing draws a sense of worth from the greatness of a group they belong to and did not choose. Its properties are the ones that matter online. It requires nothing of the member, neither achievement nor contribution, because membership is enough. It is available in unlimited quantity. It is defended with intensity out of proportion to any injury, because an attack on the group is an attack on the member's only supply of worth. And it is cheapest to supply by denigrating an out-group, because relative standing is easier to move than absolute standing.

Irony supplies the armor. Irony advances no positive claim, so nothing its holder does can contradict it. There is no afternoon on which it can be caught out, and it costs nothing to say or to hold. Its protective function is exact: you have already said the worst thing about yourself before anyone else could. For a person disappointed often enough, this is not a pose. It is armor, and armor is worn for reasons.

Put them together:

1. A person holds an unbounded set of threats with no available action.
2. Their only developed competence is refusal, which cannot be applied to the threats.
3. So refusal is applied to the nearest refusable thing, which is other people.
4. Group membership supplies both a source of worth and a target, at no cost.
5. The apparatus selects whatever produces the fastest discharge, and that is the refusal.
6. Irony makes the whole arrangement unfalsifiable and therefore impossible to embarrass.
7. Each turn of the cycle reduces the capacity to verify anything, because verification requires an undischarged interval. Reduced verification makes generalized suspicion the locally rational default.

8. Generalized suspicion removes the motive to build the capacity to verify, having concluded in advance that checking would not help.
9. Return to step 1, with less capacity than before.

Proposition 8 (*hypothesis*). Declining capacity to verify and rising cynicism are not independent trends but a self-reinforcing loop, and the reactive discharge is the mechanism that couples them. Verification requires an interval, the apparatus is optimized to remove the interval, and cynicism is the position that makes the removal costless by declaring verification pointless.

Each component of the loop has separate evidence behind it. The coupling between them is inferred, which is why Proposition 8 is labeled a hypothesis, and Appendix D describes the longitudinal study that would test it as a loop.

The loop, and the two chapters that follow, rest on one question that has to be answered first. If the interval is collapsing dozens of times a day, why does nobody catch it happening? Chapter 5 argues that the answer lies not in inattention but in the nature of an incorporated instrument, and that the answer changes what any remedy can hope to do.

The Instrument That Does Not Show Up

Why nobody catches it happening, and whether the curtain has actually been lifted

Any account of attentional capture has to answer an objection that almost none of them address. The objection is not *why does nobody care?* It is narrower and stranger. Why does a person who has read the whole argument, agrees with it and is actively watching for it still fail to observe the moment of capture in their own experience?

The usual answers do not work. It is not inattention, because attentive people fail too. It is not subliminal in any technical sense, because nothing here operates below the threshold of perception. And nobody is lying.

The answer assembles three literatures that have not been put together for this purpose before. An incorporated instrument does not appear in experience as an instrument. An instrument optimized against its own breakdown never becomes visible at all, because breakdown is how a person discovers they were inside a structure. And the sense of having chosen is manufactured after the fact, from cues an arrangement can supply. Together these establish something narrower and more important than a causal claim. First-person report is not a competent instrument for detecting this kind of shaping, so the absence of a felt compulsion is worth nothing as evidence. The result is defensive. It removes a defense rather than proving a charge, but the defense it removes is the one doing nearly all the work in ordinary arguments about this subject. The chapter then uses the result to

answer a question people ask constantly and answer badly: has the anonymous authority of the present actually been revealed, or is it still behind the curtain?

The incorporated instrument

Maurice Merleau-Ponty's *Phenomenology of Perception* (1945/2012) makes a claim about the body that most later discussion of technology has never absorbed.

He describes a form of directedness toward the world that is neither propositional nor representational, which he calls *motor intentionality*. The hand goes to the doorknob without any judgment about doorknobs. The foot finds the stair without a calculation about the stair. This is not habit in the behaviorist sense, because it responds finely to the particular situation. The hand adjusts to *this* doorknob, which is stiff, and nothing that could be called a decision appears in consciousness while it does so. The bearer of this directedness is the *body schema*. It is not a mental picture of the body. It is a practical, pre-reflective grip on the world, through which things show up *already* as reachable, graspable, climbable or too far away.

His most famous example is the blind man's cane. For a novice the cane is an object, something held, whose weight is felt in the hand and whose relation to the world must be worked out. For an experienced user it is nothing of the kind. The cane has stopped being perceived and has become the means of perceiving. The point of sensation is no longer the palm but the tip, and the sidewalk is felt *at the tip of the cane*.

His other examples make the same point from other angles. A woman wearing a feathered hat passes through doorways without calculating the clearance of the feather. A typist knows the keyboard in their hands but cannot say where the letters sit on a diagram. An organist given an unfamiliar instrument needs an hour of rehearsal, not a fresh course of study, because what gets adjusted is a grip rather than a set of facts. In every case the structure is the same. What has been incorporated stops being an object of experience and becomes a medium of experience.

Experimental work arrives at the same place by a method with entirely different biases. Studies of tool use find that the brain's rep-

resentation of the space around the body *extends to include a tool during use*. This appears in parietal neurons in macaques and in behavioral and neuropsychological studies of humans, emerging with practice and receding without it (Maravita & Iriki, 2004). Identifying that effect with Merleau-Ponty's body schema is a theoretical interpretation, not a finding, and it is used here as one. The rubber-hand illusion supplies the complement. The sense of what belongs to one's body is built from matching signals across the senses, and it can be induced to include something that is not part of the body at all (Botvinick & Cohen, 1998).

The application

The application is immediate and slightly unpleasant. The phone is not used as an object. It is incorporated. The hand goes to the pocket without a decision, as it goes to the doorknob. The thumb finds its place on the glass without searching. The reach is not experienced as an action taken toward a device. It feels roughly the way scratching does, as something the body did that one can report afterwards and did not decide beforehand.

You cannot catch yourself picking it up, because nothing in the pickup shows up as an event. The transparency is not a lapse in vigilance. It is what incorporation means.

The asymmetry

Merleau-Ponty's examples are all benign, and the analogy would be reassuring if it stopped there. It does not stop there. The cane discloses the world. The phone discloses a world that has been arranged by a party with an objective. Incorporation is neutral, and what is incorporated is not. When the cane is taken up, what arrives at its tip is sidewalk, and sidewalk is not optimizing anything. When the phone is taken up, what arrives is a ranked selection, produced by a process fitted to this particular person and selected for its ability to hold them.

So the structure is this. The medium through which the world is grasped has been supplied by an interested party, and by its nature the medium is invisible to the person using it.

That is *alienation* in the strict sense Marx gave the word and Fromm generalized (Fromm, 1961). Marx's worker meets his own labor as an

alien power ruling over him. Here what has been externalized is not labor but the grip itself: the pre-reflective capacity by which a world shows up as mattering in some ways and not others. It is also *idolatry* in Fromm's exact definition. An idol is a human power separated from the person, invested in something outside, and then relied on, and the more powerful the idol becomes, the weaker the person who made it (Fromm, 1966). The power at stake here is the power to decide what is worth attending to, which sits upstream of almost everything else a mind does.

Proposition 14 (*structural*). An instrument that has been incorporated into the body schema is not available to first-person inspection as an instrument, and its transparency is constitutive rather than accidental. When what is incorporated is a medium arranged by an interested party, the arrangement inherits the transparency.

The instrument that never breaks

Heidegger reaches the same structure by another route and adds something Merleau-Ponty does not: an account of *when* the instrument becomes visible. That turns out to be the key.

In the analysis of equipment in *Being and Time*, our primary relation to things is use, not observation (Heidegger, 1927/1962, §§15–16). A hammer in the middle of hammering is not met as an object with properties such as weight, color and mass. It is *ready-to-hand*: transparent, absorbed into the activity, and what shows up is the work rather than the tool. For a tool to be properly ready-to-hand, it has to withdraw. Transparency is not a defect of attention. It is the way equipment is properly equipment. The more available a tool is, the less it appears.

Present-at-hand is the other mode, the thing as an object with properties, looked at rather than used. It is the mode of theory and inspection. It is not primary, and we do not arrive at it by choosing to.

We arrive at it through *breakdown*, and Heidegger names three forms. In *conspicuousness* the tool is damaged and does not work; the hammer head is loose, and suddenly the hammer is *there* as an object. In *obtrusiveness* the tool is missing, its absence announces itself, and the task stops. In *obstinacy* the tool is in the way, present but unusable and blocking.

The decisive point is what happens in these modes. Breakdown discloses. When equipment fails, it does not merely become an object. The entire context of reference it belonged to lights up: the task, the purpose, the arrangement of things that had been working silently, and the fact that any of it was an arrangement at all. Breakdown is how a person finds out they were inside a structure, and it is very nearly the only way.

Proposition 15 (*structural*). An instrument optimized against its own breakdown is thereby optimized against its own disclosure. Reliability is not neutral with respect to visibility. A tool that never fails is a tool that never shows up, and the context of reference it belongs to never lights up.

Consider what the discipline of consumer software engineering consists of, described phenomenologically rather than commercially. Uptime is measured in nines. Latency is pushed below the threshold of noticing. Errors are caught, handled and presented as something other than failure. Loading states are designed so that a wait is not experienced as a wait. Onboarding is designed so that no moment of incompetence ever occurs. Interfaces are revised until nothing is in the way.

Every one of these eliminates a condition under which the instrument could have become present-at-hand. And none of it requires bad intent. Reliability is good. Lower latency is good. Graceful error handling is good. Everyone involved is doing something defensible and mostly admirable. The suppression of disclosure is a by-product of optimizing for something nobody disputes. That is why no one can be found responsible for it, and why it is the hardest kind of problem to address.

Does this prove too much?

A well-made hammer, a reliable car and indoor plumbing are all optimized against breakdown, and none of them has produced a crisis. This is the strongest objection to the argument, and answering it sharpens the claim. One condition is not enough. The claim needs three.

1. **Transparency.** The hammer has it. On its own it is not sufficient.

2. **An interested arranger.** The hammer lacks one. The sidewalk at the tip of the cane is not optimizing anything. What arrives through the phone is a ranked selection fitted to this person and selected for its capacity to hold them.
3. **Friction removed for each individual.** No earlier instrument had this, and it is the new condition. Heidegger's three breakdown modes are all forms of *friction*: the tool fails, is missing or gets in the way. A system that learns, continuously and individually, what a *particular* person finds frictional, and then removes it, is eliminating its own breakdown modes user by user. Even the residue of a person's irritation, the very moment at which the thing could have become conspicuous, is absorbed into the model and removed.

Every earlier idol was static. It said the same thing to everyone, its demands were fixed, and it could eventually be found intolerable, which is to say that it could break. An arrangement that removes its own points of friction in response to your friction with it cannot become conspicuous in that way, and that is genuinely new. Plumbing meets the first condition and neither of the others.

Disclosure happens, and does not accumulate

Breakdowns do occur. Services go down. Feeds visibly malfunction. A recommendation arrives so grotesquely mismatched that the machinery behind it is suddenly obvious. A scandal breaks and internal documents appear. In each case, just as the account predicts, public attention to the mechanism spikes, and people who had never thought about ranking systems start discussing them. That confirms the account: disclosure follows breakdown.

The question is whether disclosure accumulates, and it appears not to. The outage is repaired, the scandal is absorbed, transparency is restored and the context goes dark again. What is left is not an attribution but a memory of an interruption, and a memory of an interruption does not govern anything.

Manufactured authorship

The last line of defense is the strongest available: *I know I chose to open it, because I was there.*

Introspective access to the causes of one's own behavior is unreliable. Nisbett and Wilson's (1977) review established that people asked why they did something give fluent, confident explanations that often have nothing to do with what actually influenced them. They report plausible theories about themselves, not an observed process. Several of the individual demonstrations were small and have been criticized. The general finding has held.

The sense of authorship is inferred, not read off. Wegner's (2002) account of apparent mental causation holds that we attribute an action to ourselves when a thought about it came *before* the action, was *consistent* with it, and was *exclusive*, with no other plausible cause present. When these cues are supplied artificially, people report authorship of actions they did not produce. When the cues are absent, people fail to claim actions they did produce. The strong slogan that "conscious will is an illusion" is contested. Wegner's own claim is the narrower one: the *experience* of will is constructed.

Choice blindness is the sharpest demonstration. In the original studies, participants chose which of two faces they found more attractive. By sleight of hand they were then given the face they had *not* chosen and asked to explain their choice. Most did not notice the switch, and went on to give reasons for a preference they had never expressed (Johansson et al., 2005). The effect has since been extended from faces to consumer goods and to political and moral attitudes. In one study people defended moral positions they had, moments earlier, rated in the opposite direction (Hall et al., 2012).

Intentional binding is the compression of perceived time between a voluntary action and its effect, and it is widely used as an implicit measure of the sense of agency (Haggard et al., 2002). As a pure measure of agency it is contested, since expectations about cause and timing are plausible confounds. It corroborates the picture without carrying it.

Any reader who knows this literature will expect the finding of Libet et al. (1983) that a readiness potential in the brain precedes

the reported moment of conscious intention. For decades it was read as evidence that decisions are made unconsciously before we know about them. Schurger et al. (2012) proposed instead that the readiness potential may largely be an artifact of averaging ongoing spontaneous neural fluctuation, time-locked to the moment it crosses a threshold. On that reading it is not the signature of a prior unconscious decision. The popular reading of Libet has been superseded, and this book rests nothing on it.

Proposition 16 (*empirical*). The sense of having authored an action is a retrospective attribution constructed from cues of priority, consistency and exclusivity, rather than a readout of the process that produced the action. An arrangement that reliably supplies those cues will therefore produce the experience of authorship over actions it shaped, and the absence of a felt external compulsion is consequently not evidence that no external shaping occurred.

Look at what a recommendation interface supplies, cue by cue. It supplies *priority*: a visible option is presented, you have a thought about it, and then you act, so the thought precedes the act exactly as required. It supplies *consistency*: the option was selected *because* it matches your inferred preferences, so the action fits the prior thought as closely as possible. The fit is not a coincidence, because the fit is the product. And it supplies *exclusivity*: no other plausible cause is present. There is no visible agent and nothing pushing, only you and a screen.

All three cues are supplied at full strength. The experience of having freely chosen is therefore not weak evidence of free choice. It is exactly what the arrangement would produce either way, and so it is worth nothing as evidence in either direction.

What this establishes

Precision matters here, because this is where arguments of this kind usually overreach. The result does not establish that the feed causes your behavior. Nothing in the confabulation literature says that. These studies concern the reliability of a detector, not what the detector failed to detect.

What the result establishes is that the detector is not competent for this task. But the defense it removes is the one carrying all the weight.

Nobody made me do it; I chose to is the sentence on which the whole self-regulation account rests. Proposition 16 says that sentence would be produced with equal confidence in a world where the shaping was total and in a world where there was none. A report that cannot tell two states apart is not evidence about which state holds.

Fromm's most dismissed claim, demonstrated

Fromm's account of *automaton conformity* held that under pressure a person adopts, wholesale, the thinking and feeling the surrounding culture supplies, and that the substitution is not experienced as a substitution (Fromm, 1941). The adopted thought feels like one's own. His terms were *pseudo-thinking*, *pseudo-feeling* and *pseudo-willing*. His reason was structural. The person cannot detect the substitution from inside, because the criterion they would detect it by, their own spontaneous response, is the very thing that was replaced. For seventy years this was the most frequently dismissed thing Fromm wrote, on the grounds that it is unfalsifiable, a mechanism defined so that no first-person report could ever count against it.

Choice blindness is that claim demonstrated in a laboratory. A person is handed a position they did not take, does not notice, and then gives a fluent account of why they hold it, including in the political and moral domains where Fromm aimed his claim. The experimenters did not get there from Fromm. The paradigm descends from research on visual change detection and owes nothing to critical theory. The two routes are independent, and by the rules of this book that independence is worth noting and is not evidence in itself. The evidence is the experiments. What they vindicate is not everything Fromm said but the specific structural claim held against him. The pseudo-self is not unfalsifiable psychoanalytic furniture. It is a described and demonstrated failure of a specific epistemic capacity.

Has the curtain been lifted?

People ask this constantly and answer it badly, because three different things get run together. Separated, they give an unambiguous answer.

Level one: named. Does the phenomenon have a public vocabulary? Emphatically yes, and recently. "The algorithm," "the atten-

tion economy," "engagement optimization," "surveillance capitalism," "doomscrolling" and "enshittification" are all in circulation. Fifteen years ago most of them did not exist. Now they are ambient and cross-partisan, and people with no technical background use them correctly. As a feat of public vocabulary-building, this is a genuine and rapid achievement.

Level two: described. Is there an accurate public account of what lies behind it? Substantially, yes. There are whistleblower document releases, sustained investigative journalism, an academic literature, legislative testimony and discovery in litigation. Above all there are the public statements of the people who build these systems, who discuss ranking objectives, engagement metrics and the trade-offs between them in the trade press without much embarrassment.

Level three: made overt. Has the arrangement been converted into a decision that a named party made, at a specifiable time, on a specifiable objective, with a specifiable trade-off, to which that party can be held? Almost entirely, no. And this is the only level at which refusal becomes possible.

Apply the test to your own morning. Name the objective function of any ranking system you used. Name the team responsible. Name the date the ranking last changed and what changed. Name what was traded against what, and who approved the trade. Name one person who could be asked about it under oath. You cannot, and neither can I. In most jurisdictions and for most systems, neither can a regulator without compulsory process, which is exactly why compulsory process is the mechanism that works.

The curtain has been described, in remarkable detail, from the outside. It has not been lifted.

Naming without attributing

Naming without attributing is not a partial success. It has two specific failure modes, and both are operating.

Proposition 17 (*structural*). Naming an anonymous authority without attributing it produces a new anonymous authority rather than an overt one. The name relieves the pressure that attribution would otherwise generate, and the arrangement is thereby stabilized by its own critique.

"The algorithm" is grammatically agentless. It is invoked as necessity, as what is done, as the way things are, which is exactly how anonymous authority operates. A person who says *the algorithm buried it* has not identified an author. They have named a weather system and stopped.

The second failure is that the disclosure has been absorbed as content. Critique of the attention economy is a high-performing category *within* the attention economy. Documentaries about attention capture are distributed on attention-capture platforms and ranked by the systems they criticize. Essays about the feed are optimized for the feed. The apparatus is not merely surviving the disclosure. It is metabolizing it.

A third effect is the sharpest prediction in this chapter. By Proposition 16, being able to describe the mechanism supplies exactly the cues of authorship. Consider a person who can explain engagement optimization, knows about variable-ratio reward schedules (rewards that arrive at unpredictable intervals, the pattern slot machines use) and can name what is being done to them. Their next four hours of scrolling arrive with a narrative attached that is knowing, ironic and chosen. Priority, consistency and exclusivity are all satisfied, now with an explicit theory on top. That predicts something checkable. Critical knowledge of the mechanism should not reduce the behavior, and it may raise people's reported sense of control while leaving the behavior unchanged. If so, the critique works as a better *authorship narrative* rather than as an intervention. It does not free the person. It improves the story they tell about the same conduct.

Where attribution has occurred

Attribution has occurred, occasionally, and how it occurred is instructive. Antitrust actions produced discovery. State attorneys general filed suits that put internal documents on a public docket. Whistleblowers released primary material, not just testimony. Statutes created audit and researcher-access regimes. Advertising libraries made ad purchases attributable to their buyers.

In each case something was converted from *a condition* into *a decision with an author*. In each case the conversion was achieved by compulsory

process or by a person taking a personal risk. It was never achieved by consumer awareness, by a documentary, or by a critique reaching a large audience.

That is the operational conclusion of this chapter. Awareness is not the mechanism; compulsion is. Making anonymous authority overt is not something a private person can do to their own attention. The conclusion redirects effort rather than counseling despair. It sends the structural half of the remedy to the institutions that hold compulsory process, and it leaves to the private person the half that Part Four describes.

Before that, Part Three follows what people reach for when attribution is unavailable. There are two common responses, one disreputable and one respectable, and on the dimension that matters most they perform identically.

PART III

Two Counterfeits

The Agent-Shaped Hole

Conspiracism as an attempt to convert anonymous authority into overt authority, and why the same move made respectably performs no better

There are three standard explanations of conspiracy belief. Believers lack the reasoning skills; believers believe what serves their group; the material is produced at scale by interested parties. Each is partly right, and each misses the same thing, which is what the belief is *for*.

This chapter proposes that conspiracism is an attempt to convert anonymous authority into overt authority. An authority with no agent cannot be disobeyed, because it never commanded anything, but a named agent can. So a person whose situation offers nothing to refuse will supply something. The reach is a rational response to a real structural feature of the world, and only its object is fabricated.

That account explains three things the rival accounts do not. It explains why the form of these theories stays constant across interchangeable contents. It explains why they cluster exactly where an honest inquiry into *who decided this?* fails. And it explains why believers, as a rule, are not frightened. The chapter then reports the finding that keeps the account from becoming an apology: on the best evidence, the motives that drive conspiracy belief are not satisfied by it. It explains why that failure produces escalation rather than abandonment. Finally it ends where it is least comfortable. The educated critique makes the identical grammatical move with a true proposition instead of a false one, and on the only dimension this argument cares about, the two perform the same.

The situation, recalled

Three earlier results set the stage.

From Chapter 1 comes the citizen's condition. A person holds an unbounded set of civilization-scale threats with no common unit, timescales that differ by orders of magnitude, responsible agents who mostly exclude them, and no upper limit on the supply. That person is nonetheless *answerable* for a defensible position on each. This is an obligation that can be neither completed nor resigned (Proposition 1).

From Chapter 2 comes the citizen's competence. A civic vocabulary made almost entirely of prohibitions produces people whose best-developed skill is refusal. That refusal was earned, since nearly every institution a modern citizen was raised to trust has, within living memory, been found out in some particular.

Also from Chapter 2 comes the authority they face. Fromm's anonymous authority has no agent, issues no commands and therefore cannot be disobeyed (Proposition 4).

From those three, the hinge follows. A person whose only well-developed competence is refusal, facing a situation in which nothing can be refused, will refuse the nearest refusable thing. The threats cannot be refused, so refusal goes elsewhere: to the messenger, to the institution reporting the threat, to the expert, to the neighbor who mentioned it, or to the category of people who worry about it.

The claim

Proposition 5 (*structural*). Conspiracism is an attempt to convert anonymous authority into overt authority. It supplies the missing agent (a face, an intention, a command) because an agent can be refused and a diffuse system cannot. The reach is a rational response to a real structural feature of the situation; only the object is fabricated.

Look at what a conspiracy theory actually provides, against what the citizen actually lacks.

Table 6.1: What the citizen lacks, and what a conspiracy theory supplies.

What the citizen lacks	What the theory supplies
A bounded set of threats	<i>One</i> threat, of which all the others are expressions
A common unit across threats	A single explanatory currency: the plan
A responsible agent	A named agent with intentions
Any available action	Refusal, the one competence the citizen has
A role for oneself	The one who sees; a position of initiation
A community	Others who see, bound by what they share

Every entry on the right answers the corresponding lack on the left. A random error does not look like that. A solution does.

The idea has near relatives, and they should be named. Popper (1945/1966) argued that the conspiracy theory of society is what remains when belief in divine agency is secularized: the gods are abandoned and sinister groups take their place. Experiments show that people who lack control are more likely to perceive patterns that are not there, including conspiracies (Whitson & Galinsky, 2008). The proposal here shares their premise that a loss of control invites an invented agent or pattern. It differs by tying the invention to one kind of authority, the anonymous kind, and by saying where theories should and should not cluster, which exposes it to the tests at the end of the chapter.

Two further literatures bear on the claim, and neither is a rival so much as a neighbor. The first finds that people who attribute agency and intention to inanimate things are more inclined to believe in conspiracies (Douglas et al., 2016). That describes a disposition to see an agent. The proposal here describes a situation that rewards the seeing, and the two can be true together. The second finds conspiracy mentality stronger among voters for opposition parties, those deprived of political control, although the pattern with political orientation persists when that deprivation is adjusted for (Imhoff et al., 2022). The loss of control is a trigger. Where the reach lands is a separate question, and it is the one the anonymity claim answers. Both sets of authors also treat the reach as having a function, and the evolutionary version holds that it detects dangerous coalitions, some of which do exist (van

Prooijen & Van Vugt, 2018). The claim of this chapter is narrower: the function that explains the form is the supply of a refusable author.

Three things the account explains

Form-constancy is diagnostic

The observation that conspiracy theories share a form across wildly different contents is usually made rhetorically and then dropped. It is worth more than that, because form that stays constant while content varies is the signature of a functional explanation. Consider what each account predicts about form.

The deficit account predicts that form should track competence. If the belief is a failure of reasoning, then people failing in different ways, from different educational baselines and in different domains, should produce differently shaped errors. Errors are usually heterogeneous, and that is part of what makes them errors.

The account from motivated cognition predicts that form should track identity. If the belief is doing identity work, its shape should vary with the identity it serves. A left-coded theory and a right-coded theory should differ structurally in the way their host ideologies differ.

The agent-supply account predicts that form will stay constant regardless of both, because the form *is* the function: a single concealed agent, a total explanation, a hidden order behind the visible one, a coming disclosure, and a position of initiation for the one who sees.

The form is constant. It holds across the political spectrum, across educational strata, across national contexts, across centuries of documented instances, and across contents that share no propositional content at all. An early modern account of a hidden order and a contemporary one are recognisably the same object with the nouns replaced. That is not what a distribution of errors looks like. It is what a distribution of solutions looks like: many people arriving independently at one shape because the shape is what the problem requires.

One unglamorous alternative survives, and answering it sharpens the claim. The form may be constant because the material is *copied*. Narratives circulate, structure travels with content, and a common ancestor would explain shared form with no functional story at all.

Transmission certainly happens. What it cannot explain is why the shape keeps being *taken up*: why, among all the narrative forms in circulation, this one is selected again and again by people in the condition Chapter 1 describes. Copying explains how the form travels. Function explains why it lands.

The wall, and how to find it

The sharper prediction concerns *where* theories arise, and it is sharp because it can be checked. The account predicts that conspiracism clusters in domains where an honest, competent, good-faith inquiry into “who decided this?” genuinely fails. That does not mean where the truth is unpleasant or where the stakes are high. It means where the attribution is genuinely unavailable.

Run the test on yourself, in a domain you are not suspicious about. Pick something that affects you and was decided by someone. It might be the formulary that sets which medications your insurer covers, the model that priced your premium, the standard that defines a serving size, the committee that approved a drug you take, or the ranking function that decided what you saw this morning. Now find out who decided it, when, on what objective, and with what trade-off.

In most cases you will find that you cannot. That is not because the decision is secret in any dramatic sense. It is because it was distributed across a committee, a model, a regulatory comment period, a vendor and an optimization process, and no document names an author. The inquiry does not hit a lie. It hits a structure with an agent-shaped hole in it. That experience, a good-faith inquiry ending in an absence, is the raw material.

Test the prediction against the actual distribution. The recurring objects of American conspiracy belief are finance, public health, pharmaceutical regulation, election administration, intelligence agencies, media ownership and the food supply. Every one is a domain of genuinely distributed causation, where attribution is genuinely unavailable.

The counter-case is instructive. Domains with high stakes, strong emotional salience and *clear* attribution, such as a named executive, a signed order, a recorded vote or a court transcript, produce anger,

lawsuits and campaigns. They do not reliably produce conspiracism, because the agent has already been supplied. The theory arises where the honest question fails, not where the honest question is unwelcome.

The horror accounting

This is the phenomenological point, and it may be the strongest single piece of evidence for the proposition. Believers are not, as a rule, frightened.

An observer reasoning from the content expects terror. Suppose a person sincerely believes that a coordinated, malevolent group controls the institutions of their society, arranges the deaths of inconvenient people and cannot be voted out. The fitting emotional response is horror. The response actually observed is usually closer to *energized, vindicated and purposeful*.

The deficit account cannot explain this, and the motivated-cognition account can only gesture at it. The agent-supply account explains it by simple accounting. Before the theory, the person holds an unbounded set of threats. They are incommensurable and have no exchange rate, no available action and no locatable agent, and the person must keep a position on each. After the theory, the person holds *one* threat of which the others are expressions. They have a single explanatory currency, a named agent, an available action in refusal (the one competence they have), a role for themselves and a community of others who see.

The theory is a net *reduction* in horror, and a large one. It turns an unbounded, agentless situation into a bounded one with an agent in it. Being bounded and having an enemy is a condition human beings have several million years of equipment for. Being unbounded and facing no author is a condition they have no equipment for at all.

So the feeling is not tracking the content. It is tracking the structural relief. That is Fromm's observation about idolatry in general. The subjective experience of handing one's judgment to something outside is not humiliation but the lifting of a weight, and the weight really is lifted.

This has a consequence for anyone who wants to intervene. You are not asking the person to give up a frightening belief. You are asking them to give up a relief and go back to the vacancy, and by Proposition

1 the vacancy is worse than what they have now. On those terms, refusing the intervention is rational. An intervention that does not understand this will fail, and the failure will be blamed on the person's stubbornness rather than on the structure of the offer.

The evidence that it does not work

This is what keeps the account from being an apology, and it is the best-supported empirical finding in the book, although what it supports is the direction of the effects and not their size.

Douglas et al. (2017) organize the psychology of conspiracy belief around three motives, and that organization is now standard in the field. *Epistemic* motives are the desire for understanding, accuracy and certainty. *Existential* motives are the desire for safety, security and control: people turn to conspiracy theories when they are anxious and feel powerless. *Social* motives are the desire to maintain a positive image of oneself and one's group.

Each motive matches the citizen of Chapter 1 precisely, and to that extent the review supports the premise. The reach is toward exactly the things the situation has removed. Then comes the finding. The authors conclude that the motives are not satisfied.

On the epistemic motive, exposing people to persuasive cases for conspiracy theories increases their uncertainty. The theory promises understanding and delivers less of it.

On the existential motive, experimental exposure immediately suppresses people's sense of autonomy and control and makes them less willing to engage in mainstream political processes. The theory promises agency and measurably removes it.

On the social motive, conspiracy theories appear to erode social capital. Exposure lowers trust in government institutions and produces disenchantment with politicians and scientists. The theory promises belonging and dissolves the conditions for it.

The *direction* of these effects is well supported. Their size is less certain, because the individual studies vary in power and the field shares the replication problems of social psychology generally.

Why failure produces escalation

It might seem that this should correct itself. If the belief does not deliver what the believer came for, why don't they notice and stop? Because that is not how a counterfeit behaves, and the difference between a counterfeit and a disappointment is the whole point.

A *disappointment* fails the presenting criterion. You expected the thing to satisfy you, it did not, and the feedback is legible: the meal was bad, so you do not go back. Disappointments correct themselves.

A *counterfeit* meets the presenting criterion and fails the need. The theory *does* supply an agent, a total explanation, a role and a community. Every surface feature is delivered as advertised. What is not delivered is what those features were reached for: understanding, control and belonging.

The person has no instrument for detecting the difference, because the criterion they check against is the surface one, and it is met. The relief is real, immediate and correctly credited to the theory. The failure is slow and diffuse, and it shows up as a *deficit* rather than an event: more uncertainty, less felt control, fewer people. Deficits do not announce their cause.

Proposition 6 (*structural*). A counterfeit that satisfies the presenting criterion without satisfying the need produces no satiety, so consumption does not decline with use. It increases, because the need is undiminished and the object has been established as its answer.

So the response to non-satisfaction is *more of the identified remedy*: deeper into the material, further into the community, more comprehensive versions of the theory. The escalation is not the belief tightening its grip. It is what a rational agent does when the identified remedy has not yet worked.

What this licenses, and what it does not

The account exonerates the believer without endorsing the belief, and those two things are separable. The person reached for the only object in their environment that offered the three things they were missing. The reach was correct, and the object does not contain those things. Believers are not being stupid. They are going unfed, and reaching again is what an unfed person does.

The account also predicts a trajectory, which the rivals do not. A failure of reasoning should respond to correction, and identity work should track threats to identity. The counterfeit account predicts steady deepening for as long as no alternative supply is available, and that is the pattern generally observed.

It also identifies the target of intervention, and the target is not the proposition. If the belief counterfeits understanding, control and belonging, the only thing that can compete with it is *real* understanding, control and belonging. That is a statement about what would have to be built, not about what would have to be said.

The account does not make conspiracism harmless. Some of these beliefs have body counts. Explaining the demand does not neutralize the supply, and nothing here argues against holding to account the people who manufacture and profit from this material. If anything, the demand account strengthens the case against the suppliers, because it says they are selling to people in a specific and identifiable condition of need.

And it does not license the reader's condescension, which is the most likely misreading of this chapter. A reader who hears "they are unfed" as a polite way of saying "they are simple" has inverted the argument. The claim is that the reach is a correct response to a real structural feature of the situation. The reader also lives inside that feature, and has very probably responded to it with a differently shaped counterfeit that their own social world rewards rather than punishes.

The algorithm and the cabal

The cabal wants you divided.

The algorithm wants engagement.

The first sentence is a conspiracy claim. The second is the ambient common sense of nearly every educated person, and it appears in journalism, academic writing, policy documents and books like this one. They are the same grammatical move.

Both take a distributed, authorless, causally diffuse arrangement and supply it with a *singular noun that has wants*. Neither noun refers to anything capable of wanting. "The algorithm" is not an entity. It is

shorthand for an enormous, changing, heterogeneous set of ranking systems, built by different teams at different companies against different objectives, revised continuously, with no unified intention anywhere in them. A person who says “the algorithm wants engagement” has not named an author. They have named a weather system and given it a motive.

The difference between the sentences is real, and nothing below erases it. The second sentence is approximately true and the first is not. Ranking systems really are optimized on objectives close to engagement, and the cabal does not exist. That is not a small difference.

But truth of content is not the property at issue. The property at issue is whether the sentence supplies an agent who can be held to account, and on that property the two sentences are identical. Neither supplies one. Both end the inquiry at a noun that cannot be subpoenaed, cannot be voted out, cannot be asked what it was optimizing, and cannot be wrong.

Proposition 19 (*structural*). An agentless noun that has been given a motive is not an attribution but a substitute for one. It discharges the demand for an author while supplying none, and therefore leaves anonymous authority intact in a new idiom.

A second anonymous authority

It follows that the educated critique is the *same production* as the conspiracy theory, performed under a governor that constrains its content but not its form. Its content is genuinely and effectively constrained. Peer review, editing, professional reputation and the ordinary discipline of having to be right in front of colleagues all operate, and they are why the critique’s factual claims are broadly accurate where the conspiracist’s are not. That is a real achievement of the governor. Its *form*, however, is not constrained at all, because no governor checks form. So the same shape appears: a hidden order behind the visible one, knowledge available to those who look, an adversary corrupt at the root, a coming disclosure, and a position of initiation for the reader who has understood.

“The algorithm” therefore does exactly the work of Fromm’s anonymous authority. It operates as necessity, as what is done, as the way things are now. It cannot be disobeyed because it never commanded

anything. It is invoked as an explanation in the tone an earlier century reserved for the market or for History. In Nietzsche's term it is a *shadow*, an authority whose source has been removed and whose function persists.

The test, unflattering to both parties

Can the speaker, if pressed, replace the noun with a name? Not with a company, but with a *decision*: who, when, on what objective, with what trade-off, and recorded where. If the noun unpacks into that, an attribution has been made. If it does not, the noun is a substitute for an attribution, however true the sentence containing it.

Run the test honestly and the results are humbling. Most educated uses of "the algorithm" fail it, and that includes the uses of people who write about it for a living.

What this does *not* say needs stating flatly, because the equivalence reading is available and false. The conspiracist's proposition is untrue and the critic's is broadly true. Truth matters enormously. A reader who concludes that the two positions are interchangeable has made exactly the error that makes symmetry arguments dangerous.

What it says is narrower and harder to dismiss. On the specific dimension of whether an authority has been made refusable, the true sentence and the false one perform identically, because refusability requires an author and neither supplies one. The educated reader's advantage over the conspiracist is real in the domain of accuracy and approximately zero in the domain of agency.

In one respect the critic's position is worse. The conspiracist's fabricated agent at least produces action: organizing, refusing, showing up, however destructively. The critic's agentless noun produces a knowing sentence and nothing else, because there is nobody to act against. It is the more accurate belief and the more inert one.

What follows for practice

The standard set of remedies, which is to fact-check, label, moderate and teach media literacy, each does something, and none addresses demand. A fact-check addresses a proposition. It does not address the function that created an appetite for a structure in which that

proposition had a place. That structure is doing six jobs at once, and the truth of any particular proposition is not one of them.

Worse, and this is the part research has partly absorbed and practice has not: removing a frame from a person who has no other is not a neutral act. It returns them to the vacancy that generated the reach in the first place. A successful debunking delivered without provision increases the pressure that produced the belief. That offers a mechanism for an observed phenomenon, in which corrected individuals move to a different theory rather than to no theory.

Three things follow, in ascending order of difficulty.

Attribution beats correction. If the mechanism is hunger for an agent, the effective intervention is not *that is false* but *here is who actually decided this, here is the interest they had, and here is the record*. Investigative disclosure, compelled audits, ownership transparency and requirements for algorithmic accountability all do what conspiracism reaches for, with a real agent in place of a fabricated one. They convert a condition into a decision with an author. That is why disclosure regimes are the highest-leverage structural intervention available, and why they are an *epistemic* intervention rather than only a regulatory one. Their main work is not punishing the agent. It is supplying one.

The disclosure has to be readable. Every attributional remedy produces a document, and a document governs anything only for a population able to hold one in mind. A four-hundred-page audit nobody reads has supplied an agent to nobody.

The vacancy has to be filled with something. The remedy for ungoverned myth is not the absence of myth but the restoration of a governor: a shared object, a long argumentative record, and administrators with something to lose. Restoration is not available, because the obvious historical governors are precisely the institutions that were refused, and people cannot be asked to re-believe something they discovered was hollow. *Construction* might be available. Part Four argues that what can be constructed is neither an institution nor a creed but a *norm*.

The disreputable response to an unattributable world produces action without accuracy. Chapter 7 examines the respectable response,

which produces accuracy without action, and asks why near-universal agreement with a true critique has changed so little.

The Critique Is Ambient

Assent is a discharge. It spends the pressure that would otherwise have produced action

Near the front of nearly every book about attention, technology or consumer culture sits a sentence conceding that the critique is not original. It says that modern life is distracting, consumer culture is hollow, the feeds are engineered and institutional authority has decayed, and that none of this is news. Such sentences are written as disclaimers. They are not. Together they record the most important single datum in this book's argument.

The datum is a conjunction. Assent to this critique is very widely distributed and cuts across partisan lines, and the assent has changed almost nothing. That conjunction needs explaining. This chapter explains it in four vocabularies: as *automaton conformity*, as *idolatry*, as *alienation*, and as the attention economy's best-specified product. It then states the proposition that follows. A critique that is universally assented to and behaviorally inert is not a stage on the way to change. It is a stable equilibrium.

The datum

Take any one of the four propositions: modern life is distracting; consumer culture is hollow; the feeds are engineered; institutional authority has decayed. Now look for someone who disagrees. Not someone who thinks the framing is overwrought or the remedies wrong, but someone who holds the *contrary* position and would defend it. Such

people are rare. Most of them are professionals with a direct commercial interest, and even they concede the mechanism and dispute only whether it is bad.

Nor is any of this concealed. Engagement metrics, retention curves, session-length optimization and the trade-offs among them are discussed openly by practitioners as a matter of craft. The disclosure everyone is waiting for has already happened, and that is what makes the datum strange.

Near-universal assent was achieved within about fifteen years, on a set of propositions about the shape of ordinary life. On its face that is an extraordinary success for a critical literature. Then look for the change. Aggregate consumption has not fallen. Institutional trust has not recovered. The mechanisms described have not been altered by being described. Whatever has changed in fifteen years, it has not changed in the direction the critique argues for. The best-measured case is the one the critique is most anxious about. Pew's 2024 survey of American teenagers, which its authors frame as arriving amid national concern about technology's effect on young people, found that nearly half say they are online almost constantly, up from 24 percent a decade earlier (Faverio & Sidoti, 2024). The concern was public and loud, and the behavior it targeted rose.

A body of claims can be true, universally believed and inert. That is the phenomenon, and it is more interesting than either half alone.

Four explanations in four vocabularies

Whether these vocabularies are worth having can be tested by whether they explain this. They do.

As automaton conformity

Fromm's mechanism, examined in Chapter 5, works like this. Under pressure a person adopts wholesale the thinking the surrounding culture supplies, and the substitution is not experienced as a substitution (Fromm, 1941). The critique is now the socially expected opinion. In most literate settings holding it costs nothing and doubting it costs something. So its near-universality is some evidence that, for many people, it is not their own thought.

That inference must be stated at its exact strength. Universality is not proof of adoption. A true and easily observed claim would also be widely held, and these claims are true. What makes the inference respectable is a *signature*, and the signature is specific and checkable.

The critique is held with confidence out of proportion to the holder's ability to specify it. Ask an assenting person for the mechanism and the usual answer is "dopamine." That is not the mechanism, it is not what the pharmacology says, and it is a placeholder occupying the position of an explanation.

It does not vary with evidence. A genuinely held empirical belief moves when the evidence moves. This one does not. It is held at the same strength by people who have read the literature and people who have read a headline, and it did not weaken when several of its supporting studies failed to replicate.

And it does not show up in conduct. This is the distinguishing test, and anyone can run it. Does the assenting person behave differently from someone who has never encountered the critique? Overwhelmingly, the answer appears to be no.

A belief that is confidently held, insensitive to evidence, unable to state its own mechanism and causally disconnected from behavior is not functioning as a belief. It is functioning as a signal of membership, which is precisely what pseudo-thinking is for.

As idolatry

Fromm's definition of an idol is general and has nothing to do with religion. An idol is a human power that has been separated from the person, invested in something outside, and then obeyed, and as the idol grows more powerful, the person who made it grows weaker (Fromm, 1966). The exchange is zero-sum and runs in one direction.

The critique has become an idol of this kind. The human power at stake is judgment about one's own attention: the ordinary, unglamorous, entirely available capacity to look at what one did with an afternoon and form a view about it. Instead of exercising that judgment, the person defers to a ready-made public account. *The algorithm got me. My attention span is cooked. We're all cooked.*

These are not analyses. They are devotional formulas, and their function is to discharge the obligation to look. They arrive fully formed, require no examination of the actual afternoon, cannot be wrong and give the speaker standing. The ratio holds exactly. As the public account of attentional capture becomes more powerful, more articulate and more universally available, the individual's capacity to examine their own afternoon weakens, because a conclusion has pre-empted the examination. The idol answers the question so that you do not have to ask it.

As alienation

Marx's structure, which Fromm took over and generalized, is that one's own product confronts one as an external power. Here the product is the critique itself. Critical capacity, the activity of looking at an arrangement and working out what it is doing, has been externalized into a genre that people consume: essays, podcasts, documentaries, newsletters and treatises. The person no longer performs the critique. They subscribe to it.

The alienation is complete in Marx's sense. The activity has become a thing, the thing is produced by specialists and exchanged on a market, and the person stands to their own critical capacity as a customer stands to a supplier. This book belongs to that genre, and saying so does not exempt it.

As the attention economy's best-specified product

This is the least moralistic description, and possibly the most damning. Score the critique of the attention economy against the attributes an attention market selects for.

- It is emotionally arousing, because it concerns a threat to the self.
- It is flattering, because it casts the reader as one of the few who see.
- It requires no action after assent.
- It confers status, because holding it marks the holder as thoughtful.
- It never resolves, because the condition it describes persists.

- It can be repeated indefinitely: the same argument can be sold to the same person over and over with new examples.

That is not an accidental fit. It is the specification of an ideal engagement product, and the critique meets every clause. That brings it under the counterfeit structure described in Chapter 6 (Proposition 6). The critique meets the presenting criterion, *I am attending to the problem of my attention*, without meeting the need, which is that the attention itself is unchanged. So it produces no satiety, and consumption rises. The genre's growth over fifteen years is therefore not evidence that the critique is winning. It is exactly what the counterfeit structure predicts.

The proposition

Proposition 18 (*hypothesis*). A critique that is universally assented to and behaviorally inert is not an intermediate stage on the way to change. It is a stable equilibrium, because assent discharges the pressure that would otherwise have produced action.

The last clause is the mechanism, and it connects this chapter to Chapter 4. Recognition is a discharge. Reading a passage like this one and thinking *yes, exactly* is a completed act: the impulse arrives and leaves as agreement. The pressure is spent, nothing further is required, and nothing further happens. So the critique is not merely failing to help. It may be the most efficient available means of not acting, because it converts the discomfort that might have produced a change into the satisfaction of having understood.

Why the mechanism is worse than it looks

Chapter 5 established that the sense of having chosen is assembled after the fact from cues of priority, consistency and exclusivity, rather than read off the process that produced the action (Proposition 16). Being able to describe the mechanism supplies exactly those cues. A person who can explain engagement optimization experiences their next four hours of scrolling as *knowing, ironic and chosen*. The theory came first, it is consistent with the act, and no outside agent is visible.

So the critique does not free the person. It improves the story they tell about the same conduct. That is a checkable prediction. Critical knowledge of the mechanism should not reduce the behavior, and

it may raise reported feelings of control while leaving the behavior unchanged.

What room this leaves for a book

Two conclusions in this book sit uneasily together, and setting them side by side is more useful than resolving them. Chapter 5 found that the only thing that has ever converted a diffuse arrangement into a decision with an author is compulsory process or personal risk. Consumer awareness, documentaries and critiques that reach a large audience never have. This chapter finds that critique is a counterfeit whose consumption discharges the pressure it creates.

Together they leave a narrow role for a document like this one, and the role should be stated at its actual width. Two uses survive.

The first is as an input to the people who do attribution: journalists, litigants, regulators and researchers. For them, an account of *why* attribution rather than education is the operative lever bears on decisions. That audience is real and small, and it is not the audience most writing in this genre addresses.

The second is as something that can be checked against its author's conduct, which is the only property that distinguishes a held critique from an ambient one. Sincerity is expensive precisely because the claimant's own behavior can falsify it. This book claims that attention is the seat of civic capacity, that construction requires tolerating public incompetence, and that norms are built by modeling rather than advocating. Every one of those claims can be falsified by its author's next month. That exposure is the price of the claims being held rather than ambient, and it is the same price the book asks the reader to pay.

Three consequences

Agreement with this chapter is worth nothing, and that is a claim, not modesty. If Proposition 18 is right, a reader who agrees with everything here and changes nothing has performed exactly the operation it describes.

So the argument cannot be argued *for*. An argument produces assent, and assent is the failure mode. That is why the constructive ma-

terial in this book consists of *arrangements* rather than persuasions, and why the norms of Chapter 9 are to be *modeled* rather than advocated. Advocacy produces agreement. Modeling changes what is normal.

The right response to this chapter, then, is not to agree with it. It is to run the conduct test on yourself, once and honestly: *does my behavior differ from that of someone who has never encountered any of this?* The test takes about a minute, produces no content and cannot be posted. It is the only part of this chapter that would count as evidence of anything.

Chapters 6 and 7 form a pair. One concerns a disreputable response and one a respectable response to a world in which nobody can be named as the author. They differ enormously in truth and not at all in structure, and reading them together is the only way to feel that as an argument rather than a provocation. Both reach for something that is not there. Part Four asks what can be built in its place, and begins with the capacity the building requires.

PART IV

Construction

The Fool Before the Wise Man

Why tolerating an undischarged impulse and tolerating being bad at something belong to one family of capacities

Everything constructive asked of a modern person has a single prerequisite that is almost never named. That includes building a capacity, making something, and taking part in something instead of refusing it. *You have to be willing to be bad at it for a long time.*

This is not a motivational point. It is structural. Competence has no shortcut, and acquiring it consists of an extended period of doing the thing badly, visibly, with the gap between one's performance and one's standard in plain view. That period is not a phase before the learning. *It is the learning, and its experience is sustained, undischarged frustration.*

This chapter argues four things. The capacity to hold an undischarged impulse is a deposit rather than a cost. It belongs to the same family as tolerance for incompetence, and the two share the ingredient that construction needs. Three features of modern life have made the incompetence phase harder to enter than at any earlier point. And a culture that loses this capacity loses the ability to construct, which returns it to refusal as its only competence.

A deposit, not a cost

The usual framing treats not-reacting as restraint: a suppression, a cost paid, a quantity of willpower spent. On that framing it is depleting,

unpleasant and finite, and the natural conclusion is to minimize the occasions that demand it. That framing gets it backwards.

Proposition 9 (*structural*). An undischarged impulse is not a cost paid but a deposit made. The energy that would have gone into the discharge remains available, and the capacity to hold it is itself built by holding it.

Two traditions support this, and neither cites the other.

The first is Aristotle's account of *hexis*, the settled disposition (Aristotle, ca. 350 B.C.E./2009, Book II). A disposition is not a decision. It is the sediment of repetitions. One does not become courageous by deciding to be courageous, but by doing courageous things until the doing has changed what one is. On this account the repetitions are *constitutive*, not evidential. They do not demonstrate a disposition; they build one. Each held impulse is not a test passed but a brick laid.

The second is Jung's account of *containment*. The governing image is the alchemical vessel, the *vas bene clausum*, a well-sealed vessel in which a transformation takes place only if the contents do not escape (Jung, 1944/1968b). Jung held that psychic tension between opposites, if it is not discharged prematurely, produces something that neither pole contained. Premature discharge can mean acting out, projecting onto someone else, or settling the tension with a decision made only to end the discomfort. A discharged impulse is a vessel with a hole in it: the material leaves and nothing is produced.

Why the framing has practical consequences

If not-reacting is a *cost*, the rational strategy is avoidance: reduce the occasions, remove the stimuli, minimize the demand. That is the subtraction remedy. Proposition 2 has already said what subtraction without provision does: it delivers more freedom-*from* to a person short of freedom-*to*.

If not-reacting is a *deposit*, the rational strategy is exposure at a manageable dose, with enough occasions to build the capacity and not so many that it collapses. That is the logic of *training* rather than the logic of *hygiene*, and it points to a completely different set of practices.

The deposit view also explains something the depletion view handles badly. People who have spent years in occupations that require held tension do not generally report that the capacity ran out. That in-

cludes clinicians, negotiators, teachers, musicians, and anyone whose work involves not saying the obvious thing. They report that it grew. The empirical literature that bears most directly on this question, the research on “ego depletion,” has suffered serious replication failures (Hagger et al., 2016). This book builds on neither side of that dispute, and the argument here is theoretical.

The prerequisite nobody names

Every constructive demand requires an extended period of being visibly bad at something: building a capacity, making something, tolerating a disagreement long enough to learn from it, moving from refusal to construction. The experience of that period is sustained, undischarged frustration. Proposition 9's capacity is therefore not one virtue among several. It is the enabling condition of construction itself.

Proposition 10 (*structural*). Tolerating an undischarged impulse and tolerating being bad at something share one ingredient: remaining in an aversive state without acting to end it. They belong to a single family of capacities, and a culture that stops exercising the first has removed the training the second depends on. Such a culture cannot build the second, and therefore cannot construct, which returns it to refusal as its only remaining competence.

This is the connection most worth taking from the chapter. A culture's inability to construct is not mainly a failure of imagination, will or vision. It is downstream of a lost tolerance for incompetence, and that tolerance draws on the same ingredient as the tolerance for undischarged frustration.

Refusal, by contrast, needs no incompetence phase at all. You are good at refusing from the first attempt. That is exactly why a culture that has lost the capacity for the incompetence phase will find that refusal is the only competence it seems to have, and will mistake that finding for a judgment about the world.

One capacity, or a family of them?

Proposition 10 invites an obvious challenge: are these really one thing? Clinical psychology has asked the same question for two decades under the name *distress tolerance*, the ability to withstand aversive experience. Researchers commonly treat tolerance of negative emotion,

of frustration and of physical discomfort as dimensions of a single higher-order construct, and they argue about what else belongs under it (Wesner et al., 2023). The structure is not settled. In one student sample, behavioral tasks and self-report scales of distress tolerance did not form a single dimension, or even two correlated ones (Hsu et al., 2023). The evidence supports a family of related tolerances, not a single faculty, and it explains why the book's claim is narrower than "the same capacity." The two tolerances share the ingredient that matters for construction, staying in an aversive state without acting to end it, and what exercises one exercises the other. Whether practice in one transfers to the other is an empirical question, and Appendix D lists it as a test.

The same literature gives the incompetence phase a better record than the book first assumed. Kapur's (2015) research on *productive failure* finds that students who struggle with a problem before being taught its solution later show better conceptual understanding and transfer than students taught directly. A meta-analysis of the twelve experimental studies it could use found a moderately positive effect of learning from failure (Darabi et al., 2018). The qualification is the interesting part. The struggle pays off when a consolidation phase follows it. Failure alone does not teach. Failure inside an arrangement that turns it into understanding does, and that is the logic of norms 6 and 8 in Chapter 9, which exist to make visible failure survivable.

Three modern obstacles

Being bad at something is now visible. Learning used to happen in private: incompetence was displayed in a workshop, a practice room or a classroom, before a few people with an interest in one's improvement. Today many attempts are public and permanently recorded, before an audience with no such interest. That is not a small change. It turns an ordinary developmental period into a *reputational event*, and the rational response to a reputational event is not to attempt it. Much of what is diagnosed as risk-aversion or lack of ambition is an accurate reading of this situation.

Competence is displayed as an identity rather than practiced as an activity. If being good at something is a *possession*, then being bad at it

is a loss of possession, and the entry cost of anything new is a surrender of standing. If competence is an *activity*, being bad at it is simply the early part of doing it. The possessive framing, which Fromm called the having mode, makes the incompetence phase feel like self-destruction rather than an ordinary Tuesday.

The available supply of competence is a comparison set with no floor. A beginner at anything now compares themselves not with other beginners, or with their own last month, but with the most competent performances in the world, delivered continuously and free. That comparison does not motivate. It is Rousseau's *amour propre* with a global denominator (Rousseau, 1755/1992). *Amour propre* is a self-regard whose object is a *position* rather than a good. It cannot be satisfied even in principle, because positions are relative and nobody is ever finished with them.

The fool and the savior: a quotation in circulation

A line attributed to Jung circulates widely in exactly this context: "The fool is the precursor to the savior." It is usually glossed in just the way this chapter needs. You are a fool when you start something new, and if you are unwilling to be a fool you will never start anything.

The gloss is sound psychology. The attribution is not. The sentence cannot be found in Jung's *Collected Works*, and its circulating instances trace back only to secondary and tertiary sources. The passage it appears to have been distilled from does exist, in Jung's essay on the trickster figure, and it says something materially different:

He is a forerunner of the saviour, and, like him, God, man, and animal at once. He is both subhuman and superhuman, a bestial and divine being, whose chief and most alarming characteristic is his unconsciousness. (Jung, 1954/1968a, ¶472)

The figure there is the *trickster*, a specific mythological complex, amoral, appetitive and shape-shifting, not a beginner at anything. The relation is mythological rather than pedagogical. And the trickster's defining property, by Jung's own statement, is *unconsciousness*, which is nearly the opposite of what the circulating line is used to mean. A person who deliberately tolerates their own incompetence in order to

develop is doing something conscious and effortful. Jung's trickster is not doing anything on purpose.

The episode is worth recounting because it shows in miniature the cascade described in Chapter 1. An arresting sentence circulates without a source. Its plausibility is supplied by the name attached to it, and the name is attached because the sentence resembles something the person really said. Each retelling adds apparent solidity and no support. The full trace is in Appendix E.

The idea survives the correction, and Jung supports it elsewhere, better, in text that can be cited.

The inferior function. In Jung's typology, the fourth and least differentiated function is the one a person is genuinely and lastingly clumsy at (Jung, 1921/1971). Its properties are exactly the ones this chapter needs. It is where the unconscious enters, it resists the ego's control, and engaging it is humiliating. Development requires engaging it precisely because it cannot be performed competently. A person who works only from their strongest function becomes more *efficient*, and does not develop.

The shadow. Integration requires acknowledging what one is and does not wish to be, including what one is bad at (Jung, 1951/1959). Refusing to be seen as incompetent is a way of refusing to see the shadow. Jung's standing claim is that what is not integrated is *projected*, and that supplies a useful mechanism: a person who cannot tolerate their own incompetence will find it in others with unusual reliability and unusual heat.

Individuation as a process. Individuation is not an attainment. It requires passing through phases in which one is not yet what one is becoming, and those phases cannot be shortened.

Proposition 11 (*structural*). Development requires a mandatory phase of visible incompetence, entered deliberately rather than endured accidentally. The capacity to remain in that phase is the capacity of Proposition 9, and the refusal to enter it is not modesty or realism but the protection of a self that is held as a possession.

So this book offers the sentence in a form it can stand behind, under its own name: *the fool is the precursor of the wise man*.

The convergence

Set Proposition 11 beside three accounts of what a developed person is, and the three vocabularies arrive at one structure. Fromm's positive freedom is acting from one's own center, in spontaneous activity, rather than by adopted pattern. Nietzsche's child, the third metamorphosis, is the self-rolling wheel, the first movement, the spirit that wills its own will. Jung's individuation is becoming the particular individual one is, by integrating what has not yet been integrated.

Each of the three is explicitly a *construction*, not a removal. None arrives by subtraction, and none is available to a spirit whose whole activity is defined against something. Each requires the same enabling capacity: the ability to hold a tension without discharging it, long enough for something to be made out of it. By this book's rules, the convergence is a pattern worth noting rather than a proof. What it does is locate the target precisely.

That gives the whole argument in one sentence. *The problem is not a lack of freedom, information, intelligence or courage. It is that the capacity by which freedom becomes construction has been the specific target of the most sophisticated optimization process ever pointed at a human being, and the resulting deficit is experienced, wrongly, as a personal failing.*

Two limits keep that sentence honest. Not all frustration is productive. Undischarged frustration in a situation with no possible resolution is not a deposit. It is Chapter 1's condition of responsibility without efficacy, and it corrodes rather than builds. The deposit requires that the frustration be attached to something one is actually doing. And publicness is not always harmful: some things are learned better in public, and some communities make public incompetence survivable. The claim concerns a default, not a law. Chapter 9 is about building communities of the second kind.

One practical problem remains, and it shapes everything in the next chapter. A *resolution* to tolerate frustration is itself a discharge. The capacity cannot be built by deciding to have it. Chapter 9 asks what kind of arrangement could build it without requiring it in advance.

Norms, Not Rules

A call that does not force, and twelve norms for a medium that has almost none

Any remedy for the collapse of the interval between stimulus and response runs into a structural obstacle that most of the literature does not notice. *A resolution not to react is itself a reaction.* The instruction “do not react” is a double bind in the strict sense, a demand for a state whose defining feature is the absence of the compliance the demand requires (Bateson et al., 1956).

So the call cannot be an exhortation. What can be built instead is *arrangement*, and at the scale of a society, arrangement means *norms*. Norms are cheap and legible. They are enforced by mild disapproval, they work on people having a bad day, and private citizens can build them without anyone’s permission. This chapter states two design propositions and one deliberately unflattering test. It separates norms from rules and explains why nearly the entire governance conversation is closed to the citizen. It argues that online discourse is a norm vacuum in a young medium, which is the most hopeful fact in this book. It drafts twelve norms, each tagged with the mechanism it targets. And it closes with the case against the shrug, made only after the case for it.

The obstacle

Alan Watts called it the *law of reversed effort*: the harder one tries to produce certain states, the more reliably one produces their opposite (Watts, 1951). His central case is security. The desire for security

and the feeling of insecurity are the same thing, because wanting a guarantee already concedes that one is exposed, and every measure taken to close the exposure enlarges the awareness of it. Holding one's breath is the image: the attempt to keep the air is what loses it.

Applied to the capacity at issue, the difficulty is immediate. A resolution not to react is the anxiety produced by noticing the pattern, discharged as a plan, and the plan *feels* like progress precisely because it discharged something. The instruction is a double bind, and both outcomes register as failure. If you react, you have failed. If you succeed by effortful suppression, you have produced a strained not-reacting that is still a reaction, now with a supervisor attached. This is the terrain on which a practice becomes a metric and the metric becomes the disease.

Not quietism

Reading Watts as a counsel of passivity is a misreading, and the correction matters, because what follows is a call to act. The oldest version of his positive image is in the *Tao Tè Ching*: muddy water clears if it is left still (Laozi, 1963, ch. 15). Leaving the water alone is a decision about what to do with your hands. It is an action, and specifically *an action taken on the arrangement rather than on the contents*.

Wu wei is usually translated "non-action." It is better rendered as *action that does not force*. It means action taken along the grain of a situation rather than against it, the way a sailor works with a wind they did not choose and cannot change. That yields the design constraint.

Proposition 12 (*structural*). A remedy for the reactive discharge must operate on arrangements rather than on states. One can decide where to put a telephone; one cannot decide to be unbothered by its absence. Instructions addressed to the state are self-defeating; instructions addressed to arrangements are not.

Proposition 13 (*structural*). A practice is useful in proportion to how little attention it requires to succeed. A practice that must win an attention contest against an optimized apparatus will lose, and its loss will be misread as a defect of character.

The test is a single unflattering question: *does the practice still work on a day when you have no willpower at all?*

If it requires you to be in good condition, it will fail exactly when it is needed, because the days on which the discharge is most automatic are the days on which the reserve is lowest. A practice that works only when you are already well is not a practice. It is a reward for being well. Almost everything sold in this category fails that test, and the failure is then blamed on the buyer.

Why norms rather than habits

Propositions 12 and 13 rule out most of the self-improvement literature, which is addressed to states and requires willpower. What they rule *in* is whatever changes an arrangement without requiring anyone to be in good condition. One category of thing does exactly that, needs no institution's permission, and has been the main mechanism of social change for the whole of human history. That category is the *norm*.

A norm is an arrangement, not a state. It works through mild ambient expectation rather than resolve. Once established it is cheap to comply with, because compliance becomes the path of least resistance rather than an achievement. It works on people having a bad day. Critically, it *bounds the option set*, because a norm tells you what is done *here*, and that is exactly what an unbounded set of obligations cannot supply. Chapter 1 ended with a design constraint, that only calls which bound the set can work, and a norm meets it.

Norms are also the one civic construction that requires no coalition, budget, office or approval. People build them by behaving a certain way in public and mildly declining to behave otherwise. Political scientists call the people who start this process *norm entrepreneurs*. Their work has a recognisable life cycle: emergence, then a cascade once enough others adopt the norm, then internalization, the point at which conforming stops being a choice anyone notices (Finnemore & Sikkink, 1998).

Norms are not rules

The difference between a norm and a rule comes down to who can act. A *rule* is enforced by an authority and requires an apparatus of enforcement. It applies uniformly, it is contested at the moment it is issued, and it produces compliance without endorsement. A *norm* is

enforced by ambient expectation and mild social cost and requires no apparatus. It varies by context, it is contested continuously and locally, and it produces conduct that people mostly endorse.

The current governance conversation about online discourse is almost entirely about rules: platform policy, moderation, legislation and liability. That conversation matters, and nothing here argues against it. It is the conversation through which the compulsory process of Chapter 5 runs. But it is a conversation about what an authority should do, so it is closed to the citizen. It also inherits the central problem: a rule imposed by an unaccountable platform is the very thing that generated the refusal in the first place. Norms are the other half, and they are the half that almost nobody is working on.

The most hopeful fact in this book

Consider how thoroughly the offline equivalents exist. There are elaborate, unwritten, universally understood norms for a funeral, a dinner party, a checkout line, an elevator, a library, a courtroom, a playground, and a face-to-face conversation with someone you disagree with. They took generations to develop. They are enforced by nothing but mild disapproval. And they are extraordinarily effective.

Online discourse is about twenty-five years old, counting from the spread of blogs and social platforms in the early 2000s, and has almost none. That is not a moral fact about the people using it. It is a fact about elapsed time. Norms develop slowly, and the medium has not existed for long.

This is the most hopeful thing in the book, and after a great deal of grim analysis it deserves to be stated plainly. The condition described here is not a permanent feature of human nature meeting a permanent feature of technology. It is a norm vacuum in a young medium, and norm vacuums in young media have been filled before, by ordinary people, without anyone's permission.

Four properties of a norm that takes

It must be cheap. A norm that requires effort will be followed by the conscientious and ignored by everyone else, which produces a norm that penalizes the people who keep it.

It must be legible. Other people have to be able to tell when it is being followed. A private commitment is not a norm.

It must be enforceable by mildness. The sanction has to be a slight social cost, such as a lack of uptake, mild embarrassment, or a conversation that does not continue. A norm enforced by aggression becomes the thing it was meant to prevent. That is the failure of nearly every online norm attempt to date.

It must be modeled, not advocated. This is Watts's constraint in social form. Advocating a norm asks people to try; modeling one changes what is normal. The most common single error is posting *about* the norm instead of following it, which turns an arrangement back into an exhortation and destroys it.

Twelve norms for digital civic life

What follows is a draft for argument, not a prescription. Each norm is designed against Propositions 12 and 13: each is an arrangement rather than a state, each is cheap, and each works on a bad day. Each is tagged with the mechanism it targets, so that any of them can be rejected on the grounds that it does not do the work claimed. The tags name mechanisms described in Chapters 1 to 8 and defined in the Glossary.

1. State the strongest version of what you are disagreeing with before you disagree with it. *Targets the reactive discharge and the authoritarian need for an enemy.* Restating a position accurately means holding it undischarged for the length of a paragraph. It is the cheapest interval training there is, it is publicly visible, and it makes the exchange much more likely to go somewhere.

2. Say what would change your mind, in the same message as the claim. *Targets cynicism and the unfalsifiable position.* It costs one sentence and turns a posture into a claim. Anyone who cannot answer it has learned something. It is the single most valuable norm on this list.

3. Do not reply within the first minute. *Targets the discharge directly.* This is a norm about latency, not tone, and the interval is the faculty being trained. It is the only norm here defined purely by a delay, whatever the content, and it is the one most likely to make the others unnecessary.

4. Attribute before you attack: name who actually decided the thing. *Targets anonymous authority and the conspiracist impulse.* When something outrageous has happened, the useful question is *who decided this, and what were they optimizing?* This is the constructive form of an impulse that conspiracism serves badly, and anyone with an afternoon can act on it.

5. Distinguish “I have checked this” from “I have seen this said.” *Targets the verification loop.* Two different phrases, used consistently, would do more for public reasoning than any moderation policy. They cost nothing and are immediately legible.

6. Correct yourself in public, in the same place, without deleting. *Targets the self held as a possession.* This is the norm most at odds with managing one’s reputation, and therefore the hardest to adopt and the most revealing of whether a community can build. A community in which visible self-correction is ordinary is one in which being wrong is survivable, and a community in which being wrong is survivable can build things.

7. Do not speak about a category of people unless you could name three of them. *Targets group narcissism and the authoritarian pair.* If the out-group in your sentence cannot be replaced by three actual people you know, the sentence is doing the work of group narcissism, not description.

8. Praise specifically and in public; criticize specifically and, where possible, in private. *Targets the incompetence phase.* A medium that punishes visible attempts will not produce attempts. This norm makes norm 6 survivable, and it is the precondition for anyone building anything in public.

9. Once a month, bring one thing you made to a place where people can see it. *Targets refusal as the only competence, and supports construction.* This means a thing, not a critique, a take or a thread about someone else’s work, however small or bad it is. It makes the constructive move a habit, and it is the only purely positive norm on the list.

10. Let one contested question a day stay unresolved. *Targets the discharge and builds the deposit.* Do not look it up, settle it or argue it to a conclusion. This trains the exact faculty at the lowest available stakes,

and failing at it costs nothing, which is why it survives the days when everything else has collapsed.

11. Keep one recurring obligation with people offline, for a reason that has nothing to do with this. *Targets Proposition 13 directly.* This is the most robust item on the list. You attend on days you do not feel like it, so the obligation supplies the motive that motivation cannot. It also supplies the only reliable corrective to everything above: people who know you and are in the room.

12. Do not measure any of this. *Targets the marketing orientation and the law of reversed effort.* Keep no streak, score, log, app or thread about your progress. A practice that acquires a number has become a display, and the apparatus has been given something new to sell you. This is the most likely failure, and it will not feel like failure while it is happening.

Habits, norms and the solitary ones

Some of these can be done alone. Norms 9, 10 and 11 describe things one person can simply do, and a person doing them alone is keeping a habit. They become norms only to the extent that others can see them and come to expect them: the monthly thing is shown, the offline obligation is kept with people who notice an absence. Norm 10 is the exception. It is private training, offered because its stakes are the lowest on the list and failing at it costs nothing. The twelve are therefore a starting point for modeling, not a finished set of norms. A norm in the full sense needs other people.

Two warnings

Do not make it an identity. A person who becomes *someone who does this* has built a small monument to themselves. The sign that this has happened is that *you have begun to notice other people not doing it.*

Do not expect it to feel like anything. An interval is not an experience. It is the absence of an event that would otherwise have happened, and absences go unnoticed. A person who does this successfully for a month will have very little to report. That is the correct outcome, and it is also why nobody sells it.

Against the shrug

The likeliest response to all of this is not disagreement but a shrug. The argument has to earn its way past that shrug, and it can only do so by first conceding more than is comfortable.

The case for the shrug

The shrug is right about the arrangement. The institutional failures are real, the marketing is real, the record of betrayed enthusiasm is long, and each betrayal taught something true.

More than that, when a person cannot check a claim, generalized suspicion is the locally rational strategy. It is cheap, it cannot be embarrassed, and it is often correct.

The best evidence on this is Stavrova and Ehlebracht's (2019) work on what they call the *cynical genius illusion*, and its mechanism matters more than its headline. They tested the common belief that cynics are more astute against data from roughly two hundred thousand people in thirty countries. The association ran the other way: cynical people scored *lower* on measures of cognitive competence, academic achievement, literacy, numeracy and problem-solving. The mechanism was calibration. Highly competent people endorsed cynicism where corruption and weak rule of law made it accurate and withheld it where they did not. Less competent people held cynical views regardless of their environment.

Read generously, that finding exonerates the shrugger. Cynicism works as a default adopted when the capacity to assess trustworthiness is unavailable. A person who defaults to it is responding sensibly to an environment that has stopped supplying the means of discrimination. Any argument that does not start there is talking to someone else.

Four things wrong with the shrug

It is a fixed setting, and a fixed setting cannot be discernment. That is the actual content of the finding above. Discernment is, by definition, the thing that varies with what it is looking at. The cynic feels sharp for the same reason a stopped clock feels punctual twice a day.

It costs nothing, and therefore proves nothing. It advances no positive claim, so nothing its holder does can contradict it, and there is no after-

noon on which it can be caught out. Sincerity is ruinously expensive to hold because the claimant's own behavior can falsify it. The shrugger is not braver than the sincere person. The shrugger is exposed to nothing.

It is refusal made total. It refuses the threats, the institutions, the coalitions, the remedies, and finally the possibility of construction itself. That is not an exit from refusal as a way of life. It is that way of life refusing the last thing left, which is the future. And since a purely refusing position is constituted by what it opposes, a position that has refused everything has nothing left to be constituted by.

It supplies exactly what prolongation requires. The likeliest outcome, as Chapter 3 argued, is neither collapse nor renewal but an arrangement that does not resolve, does not break and does not improve. Prolongation is not maintained by villains. It is maintained by people who shrug, and it produces nothing but more of itself.

What the shrug buys and what it costs

It buys unreachability, and that is a real good. Nothing can reach you from behind that shelter, because you have already said the worst thing before anyone else had the chance. The cost is the same fact. A person who cannot be taken in also cannot be *met*. The habit of assessing every approach as a possible sale turns every person who approaches into an object, and that habit shapes the self that holds it.

That allows the strongest thing that can be said without moralizing. The shrug is not a failure of virtue. It is a strategy that solves one problem completely, and in solving it, closes off the only route out of the condition this book describes. Seeing an attitude you are inside requires a vantage point outside it. That vantage point has to be another person, and someone already classified as an interested party cannot occupy it.

The call, at the strength it can bear

What is asked here is not optimism or resolve. Above all, it is not that you care about more things, since caring about more things is the mechanism of the problem rather than its solution. *What is being asked is that you bound the set.*

Pick one thing that is genuinely yours to do, at a scale where you can complete it, and do it badly for long enough to get good at it. Keep one recurring obligation with people who will notice if you stop coming.

Practice the interval at the low-stakes end, where failing costs nothing.

And model, rather than advocate, a small number of norms in the places where you talk to strangers.

That is four things. None of them requires you to have a position on any civilization-scale threat, and that is the point. The inventory was never yours, and being released from it is an accurate reallocation, not a moral failure.

Notice also where the leverage actually is. Chapter 1's inventory showed that of all the civilization-scale threats a citizen is expected to have a view on, only two have nonzero individual leverage, and both are local. One is community-scale pandemic response. The other is civil conflict, the only threat on the list constituted by the aggregate ordinary conduct of ordinary people rather than by a government, a laboratory or a rock. So the conduct norms above are not a consolation prize awarded to a citizen who cannot reach the real threats. They are direct action on one of the two threats the citizen can actually reach. That is the load-bearing conclusion of this chapter, and the constructive half of the book stands or falls with it.

The evidence for that conclusion is partial, and it is worth stating at its actual strength. The conduct that feeds civil conflict is, in the research literature, largely *affective polarization*: the growing dislike and distrust that ordinary Americans feel toward members of the other party (Iyengar et al., 2019). A megastudy, a single experiment that tests many treatments at once, of 32,059 Americans tested 25 treatments designed to reduce partisan animosity and antidemocratic attitudes. Many reduced animosity, most strongly those that showed participants relatable, sympathetic individuals on the other side or emphasized identities that rival partisans share. Several reduced support for undemocratic practices, most strongly by correcting misperceptions of the other side's views (Voelkel et al., 2024). Those treatments resemble norms 1 and 7. The study measured attitudes in an experiment, and it tested treatments rather than norms. It supports

the narrower claim that the attitudes behind civil conflict can be moved by the kind of act the norms ask for. It does not show that modeling a norm moves the aggregate.

Why now

The loop described in Chapter 4 does not stop on its own. Falling capacity to verify produces cynicism, cynicism removes the motive to rebuild that capacity, and each turn makes the next more likely. Loops of that kind cannot be broken from outside alone, because no institution can install in a person the willingness to examine something. Every structural remedy worth endorsing produces a document that someone has to be willing to read.

Norm vacuums also close, and someone closes them. The norms of a young medium are set in its first decades by whoever behaves consistently while everyone else improvises. That window is open now, and it will not stay open indefinitely. This is the one item in the book where being early actually matters.

The argument is not that this will work. The structural half of the remedy is beyond any individual, and Appendix D lists what has not yet been tested. The argument is the older one. The capacity to say no is the faculty that made a person separate enough to be a person. But a No held as a permanent position is a faculty given no occasion, and a faculty without occasion withers. The occasion for construction has to be made, by the only party in a position to make it.

The task is not to be right about the arrangement. The shrugger is already right about the arrangement, and being right has cost him the thing that would have let him do anything with it. The task is to be reachable, and then to be bad at something in public for a while. Nobody else can arrange either of those things for you, and neither is available to a person who has decided in advance that every approach is a sale.

Conclusion: The Path to Renewal, Redrawn

The Introduction offered a provisional map, a four-stage arc through four thinkers who never cited one another. Jaynes supplied an origin, Nietzsche a crisis, Watts a reorientation and Wallace a practice. The map had a pleasing shape. It ran from a mind that obeyed voices to a mind that chooses where to look. It also concluded, as such maps usually do, that renewal is a bottom-up transformation of consciousness, a choice made again and again to pay attention and to care.

After nine chapters, the first three stages hold. The fourth needs to be redrawn.

What holds

From the voice to the shadow. Whatever becomes of Jaynes's history, his picture of the bicameral hearer is the purest image of overt authority: a voice, a command, and a hearer who knows exactly what is being asked (Jaynes, 1976). The rest of the arc is the story of that authority losing its voice without losing its force. Nietzsche's death of God is the loss of the guarantee, the assurance that values come from outside human decision. His shadows are the successors that kept the guarantee's authority while disowning its source. Fromm's anonymous authority is the shadow's mature form. It is common sense, the market, the normal and the ranked feed, an authority that commands nothing and therefore cannot be disobeyed. Chapters 2 and 3 followed that line, and Chapters 5 and 6 showed what it costs. A culture of lions, superbly equipped to refuse, faces an authority with

no face. It reaches for a face where none exists, or for a noun that gives the arrangement a motive without giving it an author.

The reorientation. The provisional map gave Watts the third stage as a metaphysical cure: the dissolution of the “skin-encapsulated ego” into a sense of unity with everything (Watts, 1966). The book keeps Watts but moves the weight of his contribution. What survives is not the dissolution of the self as a state to be reached, since the law of reversed effort says that trying to reach such a state reliably produces its opposite (Watts, 1951). What survives is the *law itself*, and the design rule it implies: act on arrangements, not on states. Watts’s real contribution to civic renewal is not a cosmology. It is a constraint on what any remedy can ask of a person.

What has to be redrawn

The provisional fourth stage was Wallace’s *This Is Water*. In that address, adult freedom is the discipline of choosing what to pay attention to and how to construe it, in place of the default setting of self-absorption (Wallace, 2009). The address deserves its reputation. Its diagnosis of the default setting is the reactive discharge of Chapter 4, described from the inside, and its insistence that freedom means attention, discipline and effort rather than the absence of constraint is Fromm’s freedom-to in a commencement speaker’s voice.

As a *practice*, though, it fails the test of Chapter 9. “Choose what you pay attention to” is an instruction addressed to a state. It asks a person to win, by resolve, an attention contest against an apparatus optimized to win it, and to do so on the days when their reserve is lowest. By Proposition 13 such a practice will lose, and its loss will be misread as a defect of character.

The address’s own fate makes the point more sharply than any argument could. *This Is Water* became one of the most widely shared commencement speeches ever given. It has been excerpted, animated, quoted on posters and nodded along to by millions of readers. By the analysis of Chapter 7, that reception is not evidence that the practice spread. It is the signature of an ambient critique: universally assented to, flattering to the reader, requiring nothing after assent, and

repeatable without end. The insight was right, and its form made it consumable.

So the fourth stage is not a transformation of consciousness. It has two halves, and neither works alone.

The structural half belongs to the institutions that hold compulsory process. Chapter 5 found that every successful conversion it could find of an anonymous arrangement into a decision with an author was achieved by discovery, compelled audit, statutory researcher access, or a person taking a personal risk. Awareness never achieved it. Renewal at this level means making authority speak again, supplying the agent that conspiracism fabricates and the critique only names. It is Jaynes's voice restored in the only form a modern democracy can accept: an author, on the record, who can be asked what they were optimizing.

The personal half belongs to anyone, and it lies in arrangements rather than in attention. It means bounding the set, keeping one obligation with people who will notice an absence, practicing the interval where failing costs nothing, and modeling a few norms in the places where strangers talk. Attention is still the faculty at stake. But it is trained by arrangement, not commanded by resolve.

The norm as an authority with authors

One question has been waiting since Chapter 2, and it is the right one to end on. A norm is *what is done here*. That is exactly the form of anonymous authority the book has spent nine chapters diagnosing. Is the remedy simply the disease in a friendlier form?

It is not, and the difference is the book's last claim. Fromm's anonymous authority is anonymous because its authors are hidden. They are distributed across committees, models and optimization processes, out of reach of the people it governs. A norm is anonymous for the opposite reason. Its authors are *everyone in the room*. Each person who follows it re-enacts it, each person who declines to follow it revises it, and its whole enforcement apparatus is the mild response of the people it binds. It is the one form of authority that is both impersonal and revisable by those subject to it. It cannot be subpoenaed, but it does not need to be, because it can be changed from the inside by anyone willing to behave differently in public and let the difference be seen.

The camel bore what it was given. The lion refused it, and was right to. The child's first movement is not submission to a new command. It is taking part in making the arrangements one lives under. That is a capacity rather than a creed. It is built the way every capacity is built, by being bad at it in public for a while, among people who make that survivable.

The path to renewal, redrawn, does not run from fragmentation to unity. It runs from refusal to authorship.

The Argument in Brief

Abstract

Citizens of wealthy democracies are now expected to hold a defensible position on an unbounded set of civilization-scale threats, and they can act on almost none of them. This book argues that the resulting strain is routinely misnamed as cognitive dissonance. It is better understood as a disproportion between assigned responsibility and available efficacy, a structure that clinical ethics has measured for four decades as *moral distress*. The book traces how a civic vocabulary built almost entirely from prohibitions leaves refusal as the citizen's only well-developed competence, and it uses Nietzsche's parable of the camel, the lion and the child to describe a culture that can dismantle anything and construct nothing. When the operative authority is anonymous, in Fromm's sense of an authority with no agent and no command, refusal goes looking for a refusable object.

Drawing on phenomenology (Merleau-Ponty, Heidegger) and on experimental work on confabulation, apparent mental causation and choice blindness, the book argues that first-person report cannot detect the shaping of attention by incorporated, breakdown-resistant instruments, because the sense of authorship is assembled after the fact from cues an arrangement can supply. It then analyzes two counterfeit responses. One is conspiracism, which supplies a fabricated agent and, on the evidence, fails to satisfy the epistemic, existential and social motives that drive it. The other is the near-universally accepted critique of the attention economy. That critique is accurate and behaviorally

inert, and the book proposes that assent itself discharges the pressure that would have produced action. The two differ enormously in truth and not at all in structure.

The constructive argument identifies a family of capacities behind construction, centered on tolerating an undischarged impulse, which belongs to the same family as tolerating being bad at something. Because a resolution not to react is itself a reaction, remedies must operate on arrangements rather than on states. At civic scale that means norms, which are cheap, legible, enforced by mildness and built by modeling rather than advocacy. The book proposes twelve norms for online discourse, a medium it treats as a norm vacuum in its first decades. It locates the citizen's real leverage in civil conflict, the one civilization-scale threat made up of ordinary conduct. And it redraws a four-stage arc from Jaynes to Wallace so that it ends not in a transformation of consciousness but in a movement from refusal to authorship. Nineteen numbered propositions carry the argument, each stated with the observation that would refute it.

Keywords by field

Philosophy: negative and positive liberty; nihilism; the three metamorphoses; the Last Man; anonymous authority; *hexis*; *wu wei*.

Phenomenology: motor intentionality; body schema; readiness-to-hand; breakdown; transparency of equipment.

Psychology: moral distress; moral residue; learned helplessness and learned control; political efficacy; apparent mental causation; choice blindness; confabulation; cynicism.

Sociology and political science: availability cascades; conspiracy belief; institutional trust; norm entrepreneurship; disclosure regimes.

Anthropology and cultural studies: norm formation in new media; irony as armor; group narcissism; the authority of the voice.

Glossary

This glossary works as a translation table. Each entry gives the term's home field in brackets, a definition as the book uses it, and, where they exist, the nearest equivalents in other fields (marked $\approx$). Equivalence is approximate by design. Chapters 1 and 2 show that several literatures sometimes study one structure under different names, and the glossary records the overlaps without claiming the terms are identical. Numbers in parentheses refer to chapters.

Active and passive nihilism [Philosophy, Nietzsche] Two responses to the collapse of values. Active nihilism attacks exhausted values from strength. Passive nihilism lowers the question until it stops hurting. $\approx$ *engagement* and *disengagement* (political science). (3)

Agent-shaped hole [This book] The experience of a good-faith inquiry into "who decided this?" that ends in an absence rather than a lie, because the decision was distributed across committees, models and processes with no named author. $\approx$ *diffusion of responsibility* (social psychology); *the problem of many hands* (ethics of technology). (6)

Alienation [Philosophy, Marx; psychology, Fromm] The condition in which a person's own product or capacity confronts them as an external power. In this book, the capacity is attention and critical judgment. $\approx$ *externalization* (sociology); *depersonalization* (clinical psychology, in a narrower sense). (5, 7)

Amor fati [Philosophy, Nietzsche] "Love of fate": the test of whether a person could will their life unchanged, in every detail, end-

lessly. Offered as a criterion of whether a life is one's own, not as a cosmology. $\approx$ *radical acceptance* (clinical psychology, loosely). (3)

Amour propre [Philosophy, Rousseau] Self-regard whose object is a position relative to others, not a good, and which therefore cannot be satisfied in principle. $\approx$ *social comparison* (social psychology); *positional goods* (economics). (8)

Anonymous authority [Psychology, Fromm] Authority without an identifiable agent or command, working as common sense, the market, the normal or necessity. It cannot be disobeyed because it never commanded anything (Proposition 4). $\approx$ *soft despotism* (Tocqueville); *governmentality* (Foucault); *structural power* (sociology). (2, 5, 6)

Answerability [This book, after moral philosophy] Liability to be asked for one's position on a matter and judged by the answer. When it is detached from causal and role responsibility it becomes an obligation that can be neither completed nor resigned. $\approx$ *accountability* (political science, in a weaker sense). (1)

Apparent mental causation [Psychology, Wegner] The theory that people attribute an action to their own will when a thought about it came first, was consistent with it, and had no rival cause. The experience of will is constructed rather than read off. $\approx$ *sense of agency* (cognitive neuroscience). (5)

Arrangement [This book] A feature of a person's situation, such as where a device is kept, a recurring obligation, or a norm, as opposed to a state of mind. Remedies that work act on arrangements (Proposition 12). $\approx$ *choice architecture* (behavioral economics); *environmental design* (behavior analysis). (9)

Authoritarian character [Psychology, Fromm] A character structure combining a longing to submit to something larger with a longing to dominate something smaller, both serving to dissolve the isolated self. $\approx$ *right-wing authoritarianism* (political psychology, as measured). (4)

Availability cascade [Law and economics, Kuran and Sunstein] A self-reinforcing process in which a claim gains plausibility through repetition, and the repetition is driven by the claim's

arresting quality rather than its support. $\approx$ *information cascade* (economics); *moral panic* (sociology). (1, 8)

Bicameral mind [Psychology, Jaynes] A contested hypothesis that early humans experienced commands as hallucinated divine voices before introspective consciousness developed. Used in this book as a parable of fully overt authority. (Introduction, Conclusion)

Body schema [Phenomenology, Merleau-Ponty] The body's practical, pre-reflective grip on the world, which can incorporate tools so that they become a medium of perception rather than an object of it. $\approx$ *peripersonal space representation* (neuroscience). (5)

Breakdown [Phenomenology, Heidegger] The failure of equipment, as conspicuousness, obtrusiveness or obstinacy, through which a tool and its whole context of use become visible. $\approx$ *error salience* (human factors); *seamful design* (interaction design). (5)

Causal and role responsibility [Moral philosophy] Two of the three senses of responsibility separated in Chapter 1. Causal responsibility means being among the causes of an outcome. Role responsibility means holding a position that assigns a bounded task with a completion condition. The citizen's condition is answerability without either. $\approx$ *backward-looking and forward-looking responsibility* (ethics); *accountability* (organizational theory). (1)

Choice blindness [Psychology, Johansson and Hall] The failure to notice that one has been given an option one did not choose, followed by fluent justification of the substituted choice. (5)

Confabulation [Psychology, Nisbett and Wilson] Fluent, confident explanation of one's own behavior that does not reflect its actual causes. $\approx$ *rationalization* (psychoanalysis); *post hoc narrative* (cognitive science). (5)

Counterfeit [This book] An object that meets the presenting criterion of a need without meeting the need itself, so that consumption rises rather than falls with use (Proposition 6). $\approx$ *supernormal stimulus* (ethology); *superficial satisfaction* (Fromm). (6, 7)

Disappointment [This book] An object that fails the presenting criterion, so that the failure is legible and corrects itself. The opposite of a counterfeit. (6)

Double bind [Communication theory, Bateson] A demand whose fulfillment is ruled out by the form of the demand, as in “do not react.” ≈ *paradoxical injunction* (family therapy); *catch-22* (everyday speech). (9)

Efficacy, internal and external [Political science] Internal efficacy is the belief that one can understand and take part in politics. External efficacy is the belief that the system responds. The combination of high internal and low external efficacy is the profile of the informed, exhausted citizen. ≈ *self-efficacy* (Bandura, for the internal component); *alienation* (political sociology). (1)

Freedom from and freedom to [Psychology, Fromm; philosophy, Berlin] Negative freedom is the removal of constraint. Positive freedom is the capacity to act from one’s own center. ≈ *negative and positive liberty* (political philosophy); *autonomy* (self-determination theory, for the positive pole). (2)

Group narcissism [Psychology, Fromm] Worth drawn from the greatness of a group one belongs to and did not choose. It requires nothing of the member and is cheapest to supply by denigrating an out-group. ≈ *collective narcissism* (social psychology); *in-group bias*. (4)

Guarantee [This book, after Nietzsche] The assurance that values are found rather than made and are underwritten by something outside human decision. Its loss, not loss of belief, is what Nietzsche’s “death of God” names. ≈ *sacred canopy* (sociology of religion, Berger); *disenchantment* (Weber). (3)

Having mode [Psychology, Fromm] Relating to beliefs, skills and selves as possessions rather than activities. ≈ *fixed mindset* (educational psychology, in part); *identity-protective cognition*. (1, 8)

Hexis [Philosophy, Aristotle] A settled disposition built by repeated action, in which the repetitions constitute the disposition rather than providing evidence of it. ≈ *habit formation* and *skill acquisition* (psychology), though these lose the point that the repetitions *constitute* the disposition; *disposition* (virtue ethics). (8)

Idolatry [Psychology, Fromm] Investing a human power in something outside oneself and then obeying it, so that the idol strengthens as the person weakens. (5, 6, 7)

- Incorporation** [Phenomenology] The process by which a tool stops being an object of experience and becomes a medium of experience (Proposition 14). $\approx$ *embodiment* (cognitive science); *tool extension* (neuroscience). (5)
- Individuation** [Psychology, Jung] The lifelong process of becoming the particular individual one is, by integrating what has not yet been integrated. It cannot be shortened and passes through phases of not yet being what one is becoming. $\approx$ *self-actualization* (humanistic psychology, loosely); *identity formation* (developmental psychology). (8)
- Interval** [This book, after Nietzsche] The gap between a stimulus arriving and a response leaving. The faculty that verification, deliberation, learning and refusal all presuppose. $\approx$ *response inhibition* (cognitive psychology); *executive control*; *equanimity* (contemplative traditions, though the interval is not calm). (4, 9)
- Last Man** [Philosophy, Nietzsche] The figure of passive nihilism, who finds everything "too burdensome" and has invented happiness. A stable equilibrium that a population would choose again. (3)
- Law of reversed effort** [Philosophy, Watts] The observation that trying to produce certain states, such as security, sleep or calm, reliably produces their opposite. $\approx$ *ironic process theory* (psychology, Wegner); *paradoxical intention* (logotherapy). (9)
- Learned control** [Neuroscience, Maier and Seligman] The revised account of learned helplessness. Passivity is the default response to prolonged aversive events, and what is learned is the detection of control, which overrides it. (1)
- Lion, camel, child** [Philosophy, Nietzsche] The three metamorphoses of the spirit: bearing given values, winning freedom by refusing them, and creating. In this book the lion stands for negative freedom and a culture fluent only in refusal (Proposition 3). (2, 3, 8)
- Moral distress** [Nursing ethics, Jameton] Distress that arises from knowing the right action while being constrained from taking it. The book's condition of *responsibility without efficacy* is substantially this construct, applied to citizens. $\approx$ *responsibility without*

efficacy (this book); *low external efficacy* (political science, for the citizen's side of it). (1)

Moral residue and the crescendo effect [Nursing ethics, Epstein and Hamric] The lasting weight of unresolved episodes of moral distress, which raises the baseline for the next episode and can end in withdrawal or numbing. (1)

Norm [Sociology; political science] A standard of conduct enforced by ambient expectation and mild social cost rather than by an authority. It is anonymous in origin but revisable by everyone it binds. $\approx$ *descriptive and injunctive norms* (social psychology); *custom; etiquette*. (9, Conclusion)

Norm entrepreneur [International relations, Finnemore and Sikkink] A person or group who models a new standard of conduct until enough others adopt it for it to cascade and become internalized. $\approx$ *policy entrepreneur* (political science); *moral entrepreneur* (sociology). (9)

Overt authority [Psychology, Fromm] Authority exercised by an identifiable agent issuing an identifiable command, and therefore open to disobedience. (2, 6)

Prolongation [This book] The likeliest outcome of a culture stuck at the lion's stage: an arrangement that does not resolve, break or improve, sustained because refusal blocks every construction, including bad ones. (3, 9)

Pseudo-thinking [Psychology, Fromm] Thought adopted wholesale from the surrounding culture and experienced as one's own. Part of *automaton conformity*. $\approx$ *internalization* (social influence research); *preference falsification* (Kuran, in a related sense). (5, 7)

Reactive discharge [This book, after Nietzsche] The collapse of the interval, in which a stimulus is converted directly into a response. The mechanism the book's other pathologies depend on. $\approx$ *impulsivity* (clinical psychology); *stimulus-driven attention* (cognitive psychology). (4)

Ready-to-hand and present-at-hand [Phenomenology, Heidegger] Two modes of encountering things: transparently in use, or

as objects with properties under inspection. $\approx$ *automatic and controlled processing* (cognitive psychology, loosely). (5)

Shadow [Philosophy, Nietzsche] A successor that keeps the authority of a dead guarantee while disowning its source, such as nation, progress or the market. [Psychology, Jung] The parts of oneself that are not acknowledged and are therefore projected onto others. The book uses both senses and marks which one is meant. (3, 6, 8)

Shrug [This book] The withdrawal of a well-informed citizen from an unbounded and incommensurable set of obligations. It is the correct output of a correct procedure on an impossible input, not a failure of character. $\approx$ *compassion fatigue; civic disengagement*. (1, 9)

Subtraction without provision [This book] Removing a constraint without supplying the capacity or function it supported. Delivered to someone short of freedom-to, it widens the gap it was meant to close (Proposition 2). (1, 2, 4)

Übermensch [Philosophy, Nietzsche] Often rendered "overman" or "overhuman." Not a biological type, not a superior individual and not a state one attains, but an orientation of the self toward creating values and overcoming what one currently is. The Last Man's counterpart in the fork the guarantee's loss opens (Chapter 3). (3)

Wu wei [Philosophy, Daoist] Usually rendered "non-action." Better rendered "action that does not force": action along the grain of a situation, taken on the arrangement rather than the contents. $\approx$ *effortless action* (Daoist scholarship); *flow* (psychology, loosely, though flow is a state and wu wei is a way of acting). (9)

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Appendix A: About This Edition

This book is the first trade edition of an argument that has existed in two earlier forms. The first was a twenty-one-chapter treatise, read front to back. The second was a modular edition of nine standalone essays (Modules A–I). Each module restated its premises in full and carried its own evidence grades and falsifiers, so that any one could be read first and a failure in one would not bring down the others. A separate essay, *The Path to Renewal*, sketched a four-stage arc from Jaynes to Wallace and became this book’s frame.

What changed, and why.

The order of the chapters. The modular edition ran A to I. This edition reorders the modules into four parts, so that each part answers a single question. Module D (Nietzsche’s Two Roads) now follows Module B (The Lion’s Problem), because the two describe one structure in two registers. Modules E and F now precede C and G, because C and G depend on F’s finding about manufactured authorship, and because C and G form a symmetry pair that is strongest when read together. To make that order work, the premise of anonymous authority (Proposition 4), which the modular edition stated inside Module C, now closes Chapter 2 as the hinge of the whole argument.

Repetition. The modular edition deliberately restated the disproportion between responsibility and efficacy four times and the counterfeit structure three times, because each module had to stand alone. A book read in sequence does not need those restatements. Each idea is now stated in full once and recalled briefly, with a chapter reference, wherever it is used again.

Confessions moved to the back. In the modular edition, statements about the drafting process, unrun tests and weak points sat inline. In this edition the body states its claims plainly, and the record of what is unverified, untested or contested is kept here, in Appendices C to E. No evidence grade was changed by the move.

The fourth stage of the arc. *The Path to Renewal* ended in Wallace's discipline of attention and in renewal as a bottom-up transformation of consciousness. The book's own findings, especially Chapters 5, 7 and 9, contradict that ending. The Conclusion redraws it.

Sources from the earlier editions not carried forward. Several references in the modular edition's apparatus are not cited in this edition's text and have been dropped from the Works Cited: the conformity studies of Asch, of Sherif and of Deutsch and Gerard; Leary's sociometer studies; Johnson and Goldstein on defaults; the paired nudging meta-analyses of Mertens and colleagues and of Maier and colleagues (a different Maier from the Maier and Seligman paper of 2016, which is still cited); Orwell's *Animal Farm*; and the OECD Survey of Adult Skills. The reference apparatus of *The Path to Renewal* consisted largely of social-media posts, video pages and secondary web sources, and none of it has been carried forward. Its four thinkers are cited here from their own works.

Corrections made in this edition.

1. *The décadence quotation.* The modular edition treated "the incapacity not to react to a stimulus" as its most important unverified quotation. It is now located and verified in the 1911 Ludovici translation of *Twilight of the Idols*, in "Morality as the Enemy of Nature," §2, and the related "learning to see" passage in "Things the Germans Lack," §6. Chapter 4 quotes both verbatim.
2. *Tocqueville.* The modular edition put inside quotation marks a sentence ("does not break wills; it softens them, bends them, and directs them") that matches no published translation checked. Reeve's translation reads "The will of man is not shattered, but softened, bent, and guided." The book now paraphrases the passage and cites the chapter.
3. *Nietzsche's three metamorphoses.* The modular edition's paraphrase of the child ("a self-propelled wheel ... a sacred Yes")

follows Kaufmann's wording while citing Del Caro. The book now quotes Common's public-domain translation verbatim and notes Kaufmann's familiar phrasing.

4. *Near-Earth objects*. The modular edition's figures (over 18,000 cataloged, about 40 found per week) were out of date. A query of the JPL Small-Body Database on October 3, 2026 returned 42,758 near-Earth objects.
5. *Muddy water*. The image of muddy water clearing when left still, attributed in the modular edition to Watts, is attributed here to its older source, chapter 15 of the *Tao Te Ching*.
6. *Errors in The Path to Renewal*. That essay calls Wallace's sensibility "New Senserity." The movement associated with Wallace is usually called the *New Sincerity*. It also attributes a "single-entendre" principle to Samuel Johnson, a claim this edition could not support. Neither claim appears in the book.

Appendix B: The Propositions

The propositions keep the numbers they had in the modular edition so that each can be traced across editions. Register: S = structural, I = interpretive, E = empirical, H = hypothesis.

No.	Proposition (short form)	Reg.	Ch.
1	Distress tracks the disproportion between assigned responsibility and available efficacy, not severity or inconsistency.	S	1
2	Subtraction without provision widens the gap it was meant to close.	S	1, 2, 4
3	The three metamorphoses are developmental; negative freedom is a necessary but intermediate stage.	I	2
4	Anonymous authority cannot be disobeyed, because it never commanded anything.	S	2
5	Conspiracism converts anonymous authority into overt authority by supplying a refusable agent.	S	6
6	A counterfeit that meets the presenting criterion but not the need produces rising consumption.	S	6, 7
7	Filling every interval by default is a choice about the unfilled interval.	S	4
8	Declining verification and rising cynicism form a loop coupled by the reactive discharge.	H	4
9	An undischarged impulse is a deposit, not a cost.	S	8
10	Tolerating an undischarged impulse and tolerating incompetence share one ingredient and belong to one family of capacities.	S	8
11	Development requires a deliberately entered phase of visible incompetence.	S	8
12	Remedies must operate on arrangements rather than on states.	S	9

No.	Proposition (short form)	Reg.	Ch.
13	A practice is useful in proportion to how little attention it requires.	S	9
14	An incorporated instrument is not available to first-person inspection as an instrument.	S	5
15	An instrument optimized against breakdown is optimized against disclosure.	S	5
16	The sense of authorship is reconstructed from cues, so a felt absence of compulsion is not evidence.	E	5
17	Naming an anonymous authority without attributing it produces a new anonymous authority.	S	5
18	A universally assented, behaviorally inert critique is a stable equilibrium.	H	7
19	An agentless noun given a motive is a substitute for attribution, not an attribution.	S	6

Appendix C: How Sure Is the Book? Evidence Grades

Grades: **Established:** replicated, adequately powered and consistent. **Supported:** direct evidence, with limits named. **Preliminary:** a single study or indirect evidence. **Contested:** credible evidence on both sides. **Speculative:** plausible but undemonstrated. The propositions are not graded as wholes. Each rests on the claims below, Appendix B gives its register (structural, interpretive, empirical or hypothesis), and Appendix D gives the observation that would refute it.

Claim	Grade	Note	Ch.
Dissonance effects in induced compliance	Established	Theory's scope and mechanism since reinterpreted	1
Finite pool of worry	Contested	Recent tests favor attention, not worry	1
Identified-victim asymmetry	Supported	Strong "numbing" version used only in weak form	1
NEO catalog and Sentry status	Supported	Agency figures; completeness depends on a model	1
Dispersion of expert estimates on unprecedented risks	Supported	Karger et al. (2023): extinction by 2100 from all causes, 6% (domain experts) vs 1% (superforecasters); from AI, 3% vs 0.38%; published AI estimates differ in definitions and horizons	1

Claim	Grade	Note	Ch.
Moral distress as a construct	Supported	Boundaries debated; instruments have limits	1
Moral residue and crescendo effect	Preliminary	Accumulation dynamics less tested	1
Internal/external efficacy distinction	Established	Behavioral predictions more contested	1
Learned control (revised helplessness)	Supported	Mapping to civic behavior is an extrapolation	1
Consumption reduction leaves the sense of obligation intact	Preliminary	Literature weak, self-report heavy; nothing built on it	1, 4
Negative-goal coalitions dissolve on success	Speculative	Untested; needs a coded dataset	2
Low confidence in institutions	Supported	Brenan (2025): 28% average, near the 46-year low; partisan gap is the series maximum. "Declines in nearly every category" is no longer claimed	3
Passive nihilism widespread	Contested	Disengagement and intense engagement coexist	3
Unfilled interval rated unpleasant	Supported	Self-shock condition contested, illustrative only	4
Mind-wandering and lower happiness	Supported	Causal direction is the standard caveat	4
Prevalence of ambient fill	Supported by inspection	No systematic measurement known	4
Tool incorporation in peripersonal space	Supported	Identification with body schema is interpretive	5
Rubber-hand illusion	Supported	Some moderators failed to replicate	5
Confabulation (Nisbett & Wilson)	Established	General claim; some demonstrations small	5
Apparent mental causation	Supported	Strong "illusion" framing contested	5
Choice blindness	Supported	Replicated across domains and labs	5

Claim	Grade	Note	Ch.
Teen use of social media rose while public concern was high	Supported	Faverio and Sidoti (2024): probability panel of 1,391 US teens, self-reported; 'almost constantly online' 24% a decade earlier vs nearly half in 2024. Says nothing about adults, or about the level of assent among teens	7
Intentional binding as agency measure	Contested	Corroborative only	5
Libet readiness potential as prior decision	Contested	Popular reading superseded; nothing rests on it	5
Lacking control increases illusory pattern perception, including perceiving conspiracies	Supported	Whitson and Galinsky (2008): six experiments; supports the motive, not the book's specific claim about anonymous authority	6
Conspiracy motives not satisfied by belief	Supported	Direction well supported; effect sizes uncertain	6
Form-constancy across contents	Supported by observation	Copying not excluded; selection argument untested	6
Cynical genius illusion and calibration	Supported	Large multinational data	9
Treatments reduce partisan animosity and antidemocratic attitudes	Supported	Voelkel et al. (2024), a 32,059-person experiment; attitudes, not long-run conduct; persistence not assessed here	9
Affective polarization as the form civil conflict takes	Supported	Iyengar et al. (2019), review; the identification with the book's "civil conflict" is interpretive	9
Distress tolerance as a higher-order construct with frustration tolerance as a dimension	Contested	Wesner et al. (2023); structure debated; behavioral and self-report indicators did not form one dimension (Hsu et al., 2023)	8
Struggle before instruction aids understanding and transfer	Supported	Kapur (2015); Darabi et al. (2018): moderately positive, from twelve experimental studies; effect depends on a consolidation phase	8

Claim	Grade	Note	Ch.
Ego depletion	Contested	Multilab replication failed; book builds on neither side	8

Appendix D: Limits of the Argument, and the Tests That Would Show It Wrong

Standing limits

The book has the form of what it diagnoses. It describes a hidden order behind the visible one, an adversary, a disclosure and a reader who comes to see. Chapter 6 says this form does not sort by respectability, and the book falls under that judgment. Falsifiers and grades are a partial governor, not an exemption.

The empirical support is selected. The grades follow the stated scale, but the citations have not been audited symmetrically for disconfirming work. A hostile reader would find gaps.

The national frame may be decorative. Chapters 2 and 3 read the United States through a civic grammar of prohibitions. If a polity with a strong positive-freedom tradition shows the same paralysis under the same conditions, the frame is rhetorical and the argument should be restated structurally without it.

Two chapters come close to refuting the enterprise. Chapter 5 concludes that attribution comes from compulsory process, never from awareness. Chapter 7 concludes that critique is a counterfeit whose consumption discharges the pressure it creates. Chapter 7 states the narrow use that survives.

The weakest joints. The second and third conditions in Chapter 5's answer to "does this prove too much?" (an interested arranger, and friction removed for each individual) may do less work than the

argument needs. Proposition 8 couples components that each have evidence, but the coupling itself is inferred. Proposition 10 claims a shared ingredient and a common family of capacities; the research on distress tolerance supports the family and leaves open whether practice transfers between its members. The norm-seeding argument of Chapter 9 depends on a historical record of norm entrepreneurship whose successes may be selected on the outcome. The claim that civil conflict is the one threat within a citizen's reach rests on attitude experiments (Voelkel et al., 2024), not on long-run data about conduct. The datum of Chapter 7, that near-universal assent has changed almost nothing, rests on one measured case (teen self-reports in Faverio and Sidoti, 2024) and on assent among adults that is observed informally and not measured here.

Tests, by proposition

Proposition 1. *Decisive:* give people a bounded, completable local civic role and compare threat-related distress with controls, holding threat beliefs constant. No reduction means the proposition is wrong and the media-supply account should be preferred. *Cheap:* does distress track the number of threats or the severity of the worst? *Construct:* does an adapted moral-distress instrument load on the same factors in citizens as in clinicians? *Reassurance:* the condition should be insensitive to reassurance about any single threat.

Proposition 2. If a well-designed study finds that reducing consumption durably reduces the specific sense of unmet obligation, Proposition 2 is wrong in this domain.

Proposition 3. A defensible reading in which Nietzsche treats the lion as terminal, or as coordinate with the camel and the child rather than sequential, would refute it.

Proposition 4. If organized refusal of a diffuse arrangement (a market convention, a ranking practice, a standard of what is done) routinely succeeds in cases where no agent was identified first, the claim that anonymous authority cannot be disobeyed fails.

Chapters 2 and 3 (the lion diagnosis). *Coalition test:* if negative-goal coalitions persist after success at the same rate as positive-goal coalitions, the diagnosis loses its main empirical support. *Comparative*

test: identical paralysis in a positive-freedom polity refutes the national frame. *Reversal test*: a durable recovery in confidence-in-institutions series, or a positively framed coalition succeeding durably at scale, counts against the assessment.

Proposition 5. *Domain test*: if conspiracy claims cluster around clearly attributable domains as readily as around diffuse ones, the mechanism is wrong. *Attribution experiment (the most valuable study the book implies)*: compare correction alone, genuine attributional disclosure naming a real accountable agent, and a control. If disclosure does not outperform correction on endorsement, prefer the motivated-cognition account.

Proposition 6. Longitudinal evidence that involvement in conspiracy belief limits itself with exposure would refute it. Evidence that form-constancy is fully explained by copying, with the shape absent wherever transmission is implausible, would remove the diagnostic force of the form argument.

Proposition 7. If the unfilled interval proved to be experienced as neutral rather than as relief from something, Proposition 7 would lose its content.

Proposition 8. Longitudinal measurement of verification capacity and cynicism in the same individuals, with an arm that raises capacity, would test it. Independent movement of the two, or no fall in cynicism when capacity rises, would refute the coupling.

Propositions 9–11. *Dissociation and transfer tests*: populations high in one tolerance and low in the other, or training in one that does not transfer to the other, would reduce Proposition 10 to a correlation between separate capacities. *Depletion test*: robust evidence that the tolerance is depleting rather than trainable refutes Proposition 9. *Bypass test*: a demonstrated route to competence without a phase of visible incompetence refutes Proposition 11. *Visibility test*: attempts should be initiated more often in private than in permanently recorded public settings, controlling for the skill.

Propositions 12–13. *Latency test*: do arrangement-based interventions outperform prohibition-based ones at equal reported effort? *Willpower test*: if practices that demand high attention persist better in the field than low-attention ones, Proposition 13 is backwards. *Norm-*

seeding test: if deliberate seeding of norms fails, the practical half reduces to description. *Aggression test*: norms enforced aggressively should fail more often.

Propositions 14–17. *Understanding test (most important)*: if mechanistic knowledge of recommendation systems predicts reduced use, controlling for confounds, the education remedy is better than the book allows. *Introspection test*: reliable introspective report of the moment of reach refutes Proposition 14. *Reliability test*: if more reliable systems carry greater public attributional knowledge, Proposition 15 is backwards. *Authorship test*: if authorship reports discriminate reliably between shaped and unshaped choices, Proposition 16 fails. *Vocabulary test*: if adopting critical vocabulary alone increases attributional knowledge, Proposition 17 fails.

Proposition 18. *Conduct test at scale*: if people who assent to the critique behave differently from matched people who have never met it, the chapter is refuted. *Longitudinal test*: assent acting as a leading indicator of behavioral change would make it a stage rather than an equilibrium. *Specification test*: if most assenters can state the mechanism accurately, the conformity reading fails.

Proposition 19. *Unpacking survey*: ask people who use “the algorithm” to unpack it into a decision. The proposition predicts near-universal failure, including among professional critics.

Appendix E: Note on Quotation and Sources

The marks

In the master text of this book, a dagger (†) marks a quotation or figure that has not been verified word for word against a printed or authoritative source, and a double dagger (‡) marks a paraphrase of a specific passage. The printed body omits both marks. This note lists every daggered item.

Verified quotations. These were checked word for word against public-domain translations transcribed by Project Gutenberg. They are Nietzsche's lion and child passages and the Last Man passages (Common's *Zarathustra*), the madman and shadow passages (Common's *Joyful Wisdom*, §§108, 125), and the two passages from *Twilight of the Idols* (Ludovici). Gutenberg's catalog record credits *The Joyful Wisdom* to Paul V. Cohn. The title page of the transcribed edition gives Thomas Common as translator, with Cohn and Maude Petre rendering the poetry. The Works Cited follows the title page. The constitutional phrases in Chapter 2 are from the Bill of Rights. The modular edition's edition-of-record decision (Cambridge Texts for Nietzsche) still governs paraphrase. Public-domain translations are used for verbatim quotation because they could be verified and they raise no permissions question for a self-published book.

Unverified items (†)

1. **Wallace on being “alone with images on a screen”** (Chapter 4). This is attributed to the 1996 conversations with David Lipsky, published in Lipsky’s 2010 book. The wording circulates in several slightly different forms. *Needed*: page number and exact wording from the printed book.
2. **Jung, *Collected Works* 9i, ¶472** (Chapter 8). The passage on the trickster as “a forerunner of the saviour” is quoted from secondary sources and has not been checked against the printed volume. *Needed*: verification against CW 9i.
3. **“Skin-encapsulated ego”** (Introduction and Conclusion). The phrase is widely attributed to Watts and associated with *The Book*. *Needed*: page location.
4. **The 1998 NASA survey goal and its completion** (Chapter 1). The goal of finding 90 percent of the kilometer-class near-Earth objects is reported as set in 1998 and met. The text says “set for NASA” because the source of the mandate (Congress or NASA’s own commitment) and the date of completion have not been confirmed. *Needed*: a NASA or Congressional primary document.

Paraphrases awaiting verbatim wording (‡)

These passages are paraphrased in the text and cited to the edition of record. Quoting them verbatim requires the printed editions.

- *Zarathustra*, Del Caro translation: the camel and the lion’s holy No (Chapter 2); the rope over the abyss, Prologue §4 (Chapter 3).
- Popper, *The Open Society and Its Enemies*, Vol. 2 (Chapter 6). The paraphrase of his conspiracy-theory-of-society passage needs a page locator and, ideally, verbatim wording. *Needed*: the printed page.
- *The Gay Science*, Nauckhoff translation, §357 (Chapter 3).
- Tocqueville, *Democracy in America*, Vol. 2, Book 4, Ch. 6 (Introduction, Chapter 2). This is a deliberate paraphrase of the Reeve translation.

- Watts, *The Wisdom of Insecurity*: the law of reversed effort and the security paradox (Chapter 9). *Needed*: page numbers.
- *Tao Te Ching*, ch. 15, the muddy water (Chapter 9). *Needed*: Lau's wording and page.
- Wallace, *This Is Water* (Conclusion). *Needed*: page reference.

A quotation that does not exist

The line "The fool is the precursor to the savior," attributed to Jung, could not be found in the *Collected Works*. Its circulating instances (on quotation sites, in blog posts and in a widely shared remark by a popular psychologist) trace back only to secondary and tertiary sources. The nearest genuine passage is CW 9i ¶472, on the trickster, which differs in figure, in kind of relation and in its emphasis on unconsciousness. Chapter 8 tells the story because it is an availability cascade in miniature, and because quietly substituting a better quotation would have hidden a demonstration of the book's own thesis. Do not use the aphorism.

Other items to verify before the print edition

- Page-level citations for Fromm on the authoritarian (sado-masochistic) character and on group narcissism.
- An edition and page for Heidegger's terms (Macquarrie and Robinson or Stambaugh) and for Merleau-Ponty's examples (Landes).
- Confirmation of the original publication year (1909) of Common's *Zarathustra* in the Levy edition.

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